

RKDF UNIVERSITY, BHOPAL

Bachelor of Arts (B.A.)

SCHEME

4 Semester Academic Session: 2024-25

Self-Learning Material of ODL

BRITISH ROMANTIC LITERATURE BA-EN-401

B.A. Major

UNIT-1

William Blake: 'The Lamb' 'The Chimney Sweeper' (from Songs of Innocence and of Songs of Experience) [2][3] 'The Tyger' (Songs of Experience) [2][3] 'Introduction' to Songs of Innocence [2][13] Robert Burns: 'A Bard's Epitaph' [2][3] 'Scots Wha Hae' [2][3]

The Lamb

"The Lamb" is a poem by English visionary William Blake, published in his 1789 collection *Songs of Innocence*. The poem sees in the figure of the lamb an expression of God's will and the beauty of God's creation. The poem is told from the perspective of a child, who shows an intuitive understanding of the nature of joy and, indeed, the joy of nature. In "The Lamb," there is little of the suspicion of urban environments found elsewhere in Blake's poetry. "The Lamb," then, is a kind of hymn to God, praising God's creation while also implying that humankind has lost the ability to appreciate it fully.

"**The Lamb**" is a poem by William Blake, published in *Songs of Innocence* in 1789.

"The Lamb" is the counterpart poem to Blake's poem: "The Tyger" in *Songs of Experience*. Blake wrote *Songs of Innocence* as a contrary to the *Songs of Experience* – a central tenet in his philosophy and a central theme in his work.^[1] Like many of Blake's works, the poem is about Christianity. The lamb is a frequently used name of Jesus Christ, who is also called "The Lamb of God" in the Gospel of John 1:29 and 36, as well as throughout John's Book of Revelation at the end of the New Testament.

At first glance, this poem appears to consist of rhyming couplets, and the first and last couplet in the first stanza could be said to exhibit identical rhyme; however, the rhyme is an exact repeat of the three last words, or phrase, "who made thee," and the last couplet is a repetition of the first verbatim. The effect is that of a refrain in a song, such as a lullaby in this "Song of Innocence." The speaker is even a child. The final word of the third and fourth lines (the first couplet in the body of the text), "feed mead," rhyme identically with the final word of the first two lines, "thee," creating a smooth transition.

The body of the first stanza follows the rhyming scheme AABBC: "feed mead delight bright voice rejoice;" the body of the second, follows the rhyming scheme ABCCBA: "name lamb mild child lamb name"—a pattern found in the Bible and a kernel of a larger Hebraic technique or device. An exact repeat of the entire line is employed in the second stanza's first and last couplets: the first two lines, and then the last two different lines, with the ABCCBA scheme in the body. The whole is indeed effective, one might even say "innocent" with perfect truth. In the first stanza, the speaker, a child, asks the lamb who its creator is, and if it knows who; the child knows and tells the lamb the answer in the second stanza.

The Chimney Sweeper

"The Chimney Sweeper" is a poem by William Blake, published in his 1789 collection *Songs of Innocence*. The poem is told from the perspective of a young chimney sweep, a boy who has been sold into labor by his father. The sweep meets a new recruit to the chimney sweeping gang named Tom Dacre, who arrives terrified. The Chimney Sweeper is the title of a poem by William Blake, published in two parts in *Songs of Innocence* in 1789 and *Songs of Experience* in 1794. The poem "The Chimney Sweeper" is set against the dark background of child labour that was prominent in England in the late 18th and 19th centuries.

"The Chimney Sweeper" is a poem by English visionary William Blake, published in *Songs of Innocence and Experience* (1794). It is the companion to a poem of the same name that appears in the earlier *Innocence* collection, and works as a kind of update on the plight of the chimney sweep—a young boy forced to do the horrible work of cleaning chimneys. Unlike in the first poem, this sweep can take no solace in organized religion—he is too *experienced* for that. He is so covered in soot that he is barely recognizable, and explains to the reader that society has oppressed and exploited the natural joyfulness of his youth.

Here are two of the best-known poems in this collection, both called "The Chimney Sweeper". One appears in *Songs of Innocence*, the other in *Songs of Experience*. The background to these poems is one of the many social problems that existed in Blake's time—the use of young children as chimney sweeps. Children were often sold at the age of seven to work as chimney sweeps. They were badly treated, with never enough clothes, food or housing. They were placed in constant danger of suffocating or burning and the soot caused cancer and other serious illnesses that resulted in painful and early deaths.

"The Tyger"

"The Tyger" is a poem by visionary English poet William Blake, and is often said to be the most widely anthologized poem in the English language. It consists entirely of questions about the nature of God and creation, particularly whether the same God that created vulnerable beings like the lamb could also have made the fearsome tiger. The tiger becomes a symbol for one of religion's most difficult questions: why does God allow evil to exist? At the same time, however, the poem is an expression of marvel and wonder at the tiger and its fearsome power, and by extension the power of both nature and God.

In this module we shall survey the life and select works of one of the significant artists of the Romantic period: William Blake. We shall begin with an introduction to the life of Blake followed by an analysis and critical appreciation of one of his most often anthologized poems: "The Tyger". Both stylistic as well as thematic analysis of the poem will be done in this module. "The Lamb", another poem often seen alongside "The Tyger" will also be briefly discussed.

Life and times of William Blake: An Overview

Poet, artist, engraver, William Blake is one of the most important personalities of the Romantics. Born in London on 28 November 1757, Blake came to be known as a great artist and poet of his times. His artistic abilities were evident as a child when he enrolled himself in a drawing school and learnt to draw sketches of human figures by copying outlines from the plaster casts of ancient sculptures. Blake is known for his illustrations and engravings even to this day.

He was an avid reader of the Bible and the Greek Classics. Shakespeare's and Milton's works were highly influential in his artistic career. Since his parents could not afford his artistic training for long, Blake sought an apprenticeship under engraver James Basire. His assignments of sketching the Westminster Abbey are often considered as being instrumental in the stirrings of his Gothic leanings. Blake was accepted to the Royal Academy of Arts where he learnt and exhibited several of his works. Following this, he was employed as a professional engraver working for Joseph Johnson, a procurer of subversive literature. Blake also associated himself with some of the significant thinkers of his period: Mary Wollstonecraft, Thomas Paine, William Godwin; Rev. Anthony S. and Harriet Matthew among others. Harriet Matthew and draftsman John Flaxman were instrumental in funding the publication of Blake's first book of poetry: *Poetical Sketches*, published in 1783. His works were of both religious and secular nature. In 1784, Blake establishes his own printing press which enabled him to publish his own works.

Blake is credited with developing the technique called "illuminated printing": He made copper plates engraved with his illustrations as well as his works and he prepared his own ink with which he printed the poems on paper. Every illustration would then be later coloured by hand. Through this process, Blake was able to produce works that were often commissioned and from 1789 onwards, several significant works were developed including the *Songs of Innocence* and *Songs of Experience* collection.

Blake's works are replete with spiritual concerns. More often, these concerns coupled with the political climate of the period (the American War of Independence and the French Revolution) were highly influential in turning his works into the most radical of themes of the period. Visions had been a part of his formative years and they were instrumental in his writings till his death. Blake claimed to have

seen angels; on another occasion, he is said to have sighted the spirit of his brother Robert rise from the dead body at the time of his death. By the end of the eighteenth century almost of his works became Biblical in nature and mysticism and divine mystery began to pervade most of his works.

Blake also created some of his best known works including *Milton*, *Jerusalem* and also illustrated Dante's *Divine Comedy*. A childless couple, Blake and his wife Catherine Boucher tried to alleviate their poverty through exhibition of his works in 1809 but the event was not well-attended and marked the nearing end of his artistic career. Blake died in 1827 at the age of 69 years.

Now let us turn to one of his most celebrated poems, "The Tyger". A poem of 24 lines and 14 questions, it deals with the idea of creation: both the jungle cat as well as the work of art. Its six quatrains are made of rhyming couplets.

Analysis: Structural and Thematic Readings

If you observe closely, the poem opens and closes with the same set of lines: it invokes the fierce power of not just the fearsome tiger but also the one who created the being. The only difference between the two stanzas is that the question in the stanzas considerably differs from each other. The first stanza ends with the line "What immortal hand or eye/ Could frame thy fearful symmetry?" and the last stanza with the lines "'What immortal hand or eye/ Dare frame thy fearful symmetry?"

The tiger, we are told by the speaker, is not just any animal, but one that is "burning bright". This draws our attention to the majestic creature that the tiger is. The tiger is known for its bright and fiery fur that adds to its majesty. This 'burning bright' may also be read as referring to the intense power that the tiger has. A lonesome creature, it walks "the forest of the night" fearlessly. The speaker is

awestruck by its beauty, its immense strength immediately wondering in awe again: “What immortal hand or eye/Could frame thy fearful symmetry?” This question becomes the central concern of the entire poem: the creator and his creation. Invoking the hand and eye in these lines also make the idea of the hand and sight of the creator involved in the creation of such a majestic creature like the tiger. “Fearful symmetry” is another interesting image. Art is generally characterized by aesthetic beauty owing to its symmetry. By drawing attention to a fearful symmetry, the speaker emphasizes how its beauty is combined with its ability to wreak havoc as a predator on its prey. The sublime nature of the Tiger – its appearance of beauty and fear – is at once characteristic of this creation.

The second stanza asks the question of where the tiger was created. The following stanza exhibits the powerful creature that the tiger is; this is done by invoking powerful images of fire. The speaker wonders in which space of depth was the fire in the tiger’s eyes conceived? Don’t the lines “In what distant deeps or skies/Burnt the fire of thine eyes?” bring to our mind the space of a blacksmith, moulding and shaping the creation in the midst of fire and heavy tools? (The tools appear in the images of hammer and chain in stanza 3.) If the creation is awe-inspiring and fierce and mighty, wonders the speaker, what then of the creator Himself?

Obviously for Blake, a creature like the tiger was not created in this world, but in “distant deeps or skies” referring to both hell as well as heaven respectively. One of the conventional readings of the tiger has been that it symbolizes Lucifer, the fallen angel. This is also emphasized by the reference to the wings in the line: “On what wings dare he aspire?” The recurrent invocation of fire-images emphasizes how Blake is drawing a picture of Hell, invoked also by the image “forests of the night”. Harold Bloom’s remarks: “Like Lucifer, the tiger works alone and inspires thoughts of death; it also is strong and beautiful, as the Bible portrays the fallen

angel”.(See Harold Bloom on “The Tyger” for more on this reading.) One of the fundamental questions that seizes Blake’s imagination is not just the creation, but also the sublimity of its creator.

By beginning to wonder about the creator, the speaker now asks if the tiger of such brute force has been created, what about the strength of the creator himself? This is evident in the lines “And what shoulder and what art/ Could twist the sinews of thy heart? And when thy heart began to beat,/ what dread hand and what dread feet?”

We are then taken to the workplace of a blacksmith hard at his art work. In this stanza the questions are much shorter and gain more pace. More number of questions begins to be asked. The speaker turns to the creation again and wonders what would happen to the ones held by the tiger’s deadly clasp.

The brute strength of the tiger is so immense that the speaker observes how even the stars give up their move to dominate the skies. The speaker then wonders what the creator Himself must have thought about this creation: Was He happy to see the tiger? “Did he who made the Lamb make thee?” wonders the speaker. Is the tiger then the opposite of the gentle-eyes lamb? We must note here that “lamb” is a poem in the Songs of Innocence collection. The naivety of the lamb is contrasted by the growing power of the tiger. Blake wishes the readers to see the creator’s hand in each creation and closes the poem with the opening lines.

One way to begin thinking about Blake’s Tyger is to ask the question “How does the tiger assert itself in its environment?” In fact, what is its environment? By not providing a concrete setting, but merely referring to a dark forest and deeps and skies, Blake has been able to keep the setting and its themes nebulous. The tiger is

an elusive creature, and keeping with this spirit the reader is not given a concrete setting to locate the tiger.

DID YOU KNOW?

- Blake was viewed as a madman in his times; he is now heralded for his immense contributions to Romantic poetry.
- Blake's wife was illiterate; he taught her to read and write to help him with his drafts and publish his works.
- Blake was self-taught in Greek, latin and Hebrew.
- Blake wrote his text in reverse on the copper plates and then illustrated them
- Blake helped Thomas Paine escape to France when his *Rights of Man* was deemed too inflammatory in a revolutionary climate.

‘A Bard’s Epitaph’ by Robert Burns

‘A Bard’s Epitaph’ by Robert Burns begins with a metaphor. Here, the poet compares himself to a “whim-inspired” or fanciful fool. There is a repetition in the following two lines and those lines contain anaphora. Moreover, in “grassy heap” the poet uses a synecdoche. Here, the poet refers to his grave. In the second stanza, there is an apostrophe in “O, pass not by!” In the line following it, the poet uses a hyperbaton. This stanza also contains alliterations in “frater-feeling” and “Here, heave”. In the third stanza, “life’s mad career” is a metaphor, and the line “Wild as the wave” presents a simile. Moreover, in “starting tear” and in the sixth stanza, “But thoughtless follies laid him low” the poet uses personification. However, the last two lines present an epigram.

‘A Bard’s Epitaph’ by Robert Burns begins with a humorous tone. The poet metaphorically calls himself a “whim-inspired fool”. It means the fanciful

thoughts of the poet. Moreover, he says he was too fast to think and too hot-headed to accept rules. For his shyness, he restrained himself from seeking and his pride blocked his mind from stooping to someone for insight. Thereafter, the poet requests the readers to come near to his grave and think about his poetic contributions. Burns thinks his death might cause one to drop a tear. However, the mood of the last line becomes emotional in comparison to that of the first line.

'A Bard's Epitaph' by Robert Burns highlights the quality of the poet's compositions and how his countrymen feel about him. Burns was popular for his "rustic" poetry that has the essence of rural Scotland. Moreover, the poet says his grave steals the crowds from the other poet's grave, and the crowd throngs around his grave weekly. By using a litote, the poet says they don't pass by. Rather, people feel sad about the loss of one of their brothers. With a strong brotherly feeling, they heave a sigh to think about the dead poet.

The third stanza of *'A Bard's Epitaph'* by Robert Burns refers to a specific man standing among the crowd. He appears to be wide and judgemental. The poet thinks he can teach others how to live life wisely. But, he is also busy in his career like the poet. His professional life controls him like a boat floating on the wild sea. The person is as restless as the poet was in his life. Such a person can understand the poet's state of mind better. That's why he surveys the grave and tear trickles down. The fourth stanza of *'A Bard's Epitaph'* by Robert Burns anticipates what might have tarnished the poet's name. According to Burns, he was quick to learn something new and he was wise. Moreover, the poet says once he had many friends and felt the "softer flame" of friendship and brotherhood. The feeling of camaraderie is like a "flame" that ignites one's soul unlike the flames of passion that burn the heart. At last, the poet says the "thoughtless follies" stained his "name". He doesn't shy away from accepting his flaws. The last stanza of *'A*

Bard's Epitaph by Robert Burns, using an apostrophe, alerts the readers. The poet specifically draws the attention of those who soar in fanciful thoughts leaping over the limits. And, he refers to those who pursue lowly dreams. The poet advises them to know the value of prudence, awareness, and self-control. These three qualities form the foundation of a wise person.

Historical Context

'A Bard's Epitaph' by Robert Burns was composed in 1786, 10 years before the poet's death. In this poem, the poet anticipates how people would remind him after his death. However, Robert Burns is regarded as a pioneer of the Romantic movement that flourished in the last decade of the 18th century. Likewise, in this poem, there are several romantic elements. Moreover, the poet also presents his liberal mindset and socialist bent in the association of the poet as a voice of rural Scotland. That's why he was also known as the "Ploughman Poet".

UNIT-2

William Wordsworth: *'Tintern Abbey' Ode: Intimations of Immortality'*

Samuel Taylor Coleridge: *'Kubla Khan' 'Dejection: An Ode'*

Tintern Abbey

Summary

"Lines Composed a Few Miles above Tintern Abbey, On Revisiting the Banks of the Wye during a Tour. July 13, 1798" commonly known as "Tintern Abbey" is a poem written by the British Romantic poet William Wordsworth. Wordsworth had first visited the Wye Valley when he was 23 years old. His return five years later occasioned this poem, which Wordsworth saw as articulating his

beliefs about nature, creativity, and the human soul. “Tintern Abbey” was included as the final poem in *Lyrical Ballads*, a 1798 collection of poems by Wordsworth and his friend and fellow poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge.

The full title of this poem is “Lines Composed a Few Miles above Tintern Abbey, on Revisiting the Banks of the Wye during a Tour. July 13, 1798.” It opens with the speaker’s declaration that five years have passed since he last visited this location, encountered its tranquil, rustic scenery, and heard the murmuring waters of the river. He recites the objects he sees again, and describes their effect upon him: the “steep and lofty cliffs” impress upon him “thoughts of more deep seclusion”; he leans against the dark sycamore tree and looks at the cottage-grounds and the orchard trees, whose fruit is still unripe. He sees the “wreaths of smoke” rising up from cottage chimneys between the trees, and imagines that they might rise from “vagrant dwellers in the houseless woods,” or from the cave of a hermit in the deep forest.

The speaker then describes how his memory of these “beauteous forms” has worked upon him in his absence from them: when he was alone, or in crowded towns and cities, they provided him with “sensations sweet, / Felt in the blood, and felt along the heart.” The memory of the woods and cottages offered “tranquil restoration” to his mind, and even affected him when he was not aware of the memory, influencing his deeds of kindness and love. He further credits the memory of the scene with offering him access to that mental and spiritual state in which the burden of the world is lightened, in which he becomes a “living soul” with a view into “the life of things.” The speaker then says that his belief that the memory of the woods has affected him so strongly may be “vain”—but if it is, he has still turned to the memory often in times of “fretful stir.”

Even in the present moment, the memory of his past experiences in these surroundings floats over his present view of them, and he feels bittersweet joy in reviving them. He thinks happily, too, that his present experience will provide many happy memories for future years. The speaker acknowledges that he is different now from how he was in those long-ago times, when, as a boy, he “bounded o’er the mountains” and through the streams. In those days, he says, nature made up his whole world: waterfalls, mountains, and woods gave shape to his passions, his appetites, and his love. That time is now past, he says, but he does not mourn it, for though he cannot resume his old relationship with nature, he has been amply compensated by a new set of more mature gifts; for instance, he can now “look on nature, not as in the hour / Of thoughtless youth; but hearing oftentimes / The still, sad music of humanity.” And he can now sense the presence of something far more subtle, powerful, and fundamental in the light of the setting suns, the ocean, the air itself, and even in the mind of man; this energy seems to him “a motion and a spirit that impels / All thinking thoughts.... / And rolls through all things.” For that reason, he says, he still loves nature, still loves mountains and pastures and woods, for they anchor his purest thoughts and guard the heart and soul of his “moral being.”

The speaker says that even if he did not feel this way or understand these things, he would still be in good spirits on this day, for he is in the company of his “dear, dear (d) Sister,” who is also his “dear, dear Friend,” and in whose voice and manner he observes his former self, and beholds “what I was once.” He offers a prayer to nature that he might continue to do so for a little while, knowing, as he says, that “Nature never did betray / The heart that loved her,” but leads rather “from joy to joy.” Nature’s power over the mind that seeks her out is such that it renders that mind impervious to “evil tongues,” “rash judgments,” and “the sneers

of selfish men,” instilling instead a “cheerful faith” that the world is full of blessings. The speaker then encourages the moon to shine upon his sister, and the wind to blow against her, and he says to her that in later years, when she is sad or fearful, the memory of this experience will help to heal her. And if he himself is dead, she can remember the love with which he worshipped nature. In that case, too, she will remember what the woods meant to the speaker, the way in which, after so many years of absence, they became more dear to him—both for themselves and for the fact that she is in them.

Form

“Tintern Abbey” is composed in blank verse, which is a name used to describe unrhymed lines in iambic pentameter. Its style is therefore very fluid and natural; it reads as easily as if it were a prose piece. But of course the poetic structure is tightly constructed; Wordsworth’s slight variations on the stresses of iambic rhythms is remarkable. Lines such as “Here, under this dark sycamore, and view” do not quite conform to the stress-patterns of the meter, but fit into it loosely, helping Wordsworth approximate the sounds of natural speech without grossly breaking his meter. Occasionally, divided lines are used to indicate a kind of paragraph break, when the poet changes subjects or shifts the focus of his discourse.

Analysis

The subject of “Tintern Abbey” is memory—specifically, childhood memories of communion with natural beauty. Both generally and specifically, this subject is hugely important in Wordsworth’s work, reappearing in poems as late as the “Intimations of Immortality” ode. “Tintern Abbey” is the young Wordsworth’s

first great statement of his principle (great) theme: that the memory of pure communion with nature in childhood works upon the mind even in adulthood, when access to that pure communion has been lost, and that the maturity of mind present in adulthood offers compensation for the loss of that communion—specifically, the ability to “look on nature” and hear “human music”; that is, to see nature with an eye toward its relationship to human life. In his youth, the poet says, he was thoughtless in his unity with the woods and the river; now, five years since his last viewing of the scene, he is no longer thoughtless, but acutely aware of everything the scene has to offer him. Additionally, the presence of his sister gives him a view of himself as he imagines himself to have been as a youth. Happily, he knows that this current experience will provide both of them with future memories, just as his past experience has provided him with the memories that flicker across his present sight as he travels in the woods.

“Tintern Abbey” is a monologue, imaginatively spoken by a single speaker to himself, referencing the specific objects of its imaginary scene, and occasionally addressing others—once the spirit of nature, occasionally the speaker’s sister. The language of the poem is striking for its simplicity and forthrightness; the young poet is in no way concerned with ostentation. He is instead concerned with speaking from the heart in a plainspoken manner. The poem’s imagery is largely confined to the natural world in which he moves, though there are some castings-out for metaphors ranging from the nautical (the memory is “the anchor” of the poet’s “purest thought”) to the architectural (the mind is a “mansion” of memory).

The poem also has a subtle strain of religious sentiment; though the actual form of the Abbey does not appear in the poem, the idea of the abbey—of a place consecrated to the spirit—suffuses the scene, as though the forest and the fields

were themselves the speaker's abbey. This idea is reinforced by the speaker's description of the power he feels in the setting sun and in the mind of man, which consciously links the ideas of God, nature, and the human mind—as they will be linked in Wordsworth's poetry for the rest of his life, from “It is a beauteous evening, calm and free” to the great summation of the Immortality Ode.

Ode: Intimations of Immortality

William Wordsworth first published "Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood" in his 1807 collection *Poems, in Two Volumes*. Often considered one of Wordsworth's greatest masterpieces, this poem explores some of the themes that haunted Wordsworth across his whole career: childhood, memory, nature, and the human soul. The poem's speaker remembers that, when he was a child, he saw the whole world shining with heavenly beauty, and wonders where that beauty has gone now he's an adult. While he can never get that kind of vision back, he concludes, he can still build his faith upon his *memories* of it; the way the world looks to children, he argues, is a hint that every human soul comes from heaven, and will return there one day.

Summary

In the first stanza, the speaker says wistfully that there was a time when all of nature seemed dreamlike to him, “apparelled in celestial light,” and that that time is past; “the things I have seen I can see no more.” In the second stanza, he says that he still sees the rainbow, and that the rose is still lovely; the moon looks around the sky with delight, and starlight and sunshine are each beautiful. Nonetheless the speaker feels that a glory has passed away from the earth. In the third stanza, the speaker says that, while listening to the birds sing in springtime

and watching the young lambs leap and play, he was stricken with a thought of grief; but the sound of nearby waterfalls, the echoes of the mountains, and the gusting of the winds restored him to strength. He declares that his grief will no longer wrong the joy of the season, and that all the earth is happy. He exhorts a shepherd boy to shout and play around him. In the fourth stanza, he addresses nature's creatures, and says that his heart participates in their joyful festival. He says that it would be wrong to feel sad on such a beautiful May morning, while children play and laugh among the flowers. Nevertheless, a tree and a field that he looks upon make him think of "something that is gone," and a pansy at his feet does the same. He asks what has happened to "the visionary gleam": "Where is it now, the glory and the dream?"

In the fifth stanza, he proclaims that human life is merely "a sleep and a forgetting"—that human beings dwell in a purer, more glorious realm before they enter the earth. "Heaven," he says, "lies about us in our infancy!" As children, we still retain some memory of that place, which causes our experience of the earth to be suffused with its magic—but as the baby passes through boyhood and young adulthood and into manhood, he sees that magic die. In the sixth stanza, the speaker says that the pleasures unique to earth conspire to help the man forget the "glories" whence he came.

In the seventh stanza, the speaker beholds a six-year-old boy and imagines his life, and the love his mother and father feel for him. He sees the boy playing with some imitated fragment of adult life, "some little plan or chart," imitating "a wedding or a festival" or "a mourning or a funeral." The speaker imagines that all human life is a similar imitation. In the eighth stanza, the speaker addresses the child as though he were a mighty prophet of a lost truth, and rhetorically asks him why,

when he has access to the glories of his origins, and to the pure experience of nature, he still hurries toward an adult life of custom and “earthly freight.”

In the ninth stanza, the speaker experiences a surge of joy at the thought that his memories of childhood will always grant him a kind of access to that lost world of instinct, innocence, and exploration. In the tenth stanza, bolstered by this joy, he urges the birds to sing, and urges all creatures to participate in “the gladness of the May.” He says that though he has lost some part of the glory of nature and of experience, he will take solace in “primal sympathy,” in memory, and in the fact that the years bring a mature consciousness—“a philosophic mind.” In the final stanza, the speaker says that this mind—which stems from a consciousness of mortality, as opposed to the child’s feeling of immortality—enables him to love nature and natural beauty all the more, for each of nature’s objects can stir him to thought, and even the simplest flower blowing in the wind can raise in him “thoughts that do often lie too deep for tears.”

Form

Wordsworth’s Immortality Ode, as it is often called, is written in eleven variable ode stanzas with variable rhyme schemes, in iambic lines with anything from two to five stressed syllables. The rhymes occasionally alternate lines, occasionally fall in couplets, and occasionally occur within a single line (as in “But yet I *know*, where’er I *go*” in the second stanza).

Analysis

If “Tintern Abbey” is Wordsworth’s first great statement about the action of childhood memories of nature upon the adult mind, the “Intimations of Immortality” ode is his mature masterpiece on the subject. The poem, whose full

title is “Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood,” makes explicit Wordsworth’s belief that life on earth is a dim shadow of an earlier, purer existence, dimly recalled in childhood and then forgotten in the process of growing up. (In the fifth stanza, he writes, “Our birth is but a sleep and a forgetting.../Not in entire forgetfulness, / And not in utter nakedness, /But trailing clouds of glory do we come / From God, who is our home....”)

While one might disagree with the poem’s metaphysical hypotheses, there is no arguing with the genius of language at work in this Ode. Wordsworth consciously sets his speaker’s mind at odds with the atmosphere of joyous nature all around him, a rare move by a poet whose consciousness is so habitually in unity with nature. Understanding that his grief stems from his inability to experience the May morning as he would have in childhood, the speaker attempts to enter willfully into a state of cheerfulness; but he is able to find real happiness only when he realizes that “the philosophic mind” has given him the ability to understand nature in deeper, more human terms—as a source of metaphor and guidance for human life. This is very much the same pattern as “Tintern Abbey”’s, but whereas in the earlier poem Wordsworth made himself joyful, and referred to the “music of humanity” only briefly, in the later poem he explicitly proposes that this music is the remedy for his mature grief.

The structure of the Immortality Ode is also unique in Wordsworth’s work; unlike his characteristically fluid, naturally spoken monologues, the Ode is written in a lilting, songlike cadence with frequent shifts in rhyme scheme and rhythm. Further, rather than progressively exploring a single idea from start to finish, the Ode jumps from idea to idea, always sticking close to the central scene, but frequently making surprising moves, as when the speaker begins to address the “Mighty Prophet” in

the eighth stanza—only to reveal midway through his address that the mighty prophet is a six-year-old boy.

Wordsworth's linguistic strategies are extraordinarily sophisticated and complex in this Ode, as the poem's use of metaphor and image shifts from the register of lost childhood to the register of the philosophic mind. When the speaker is grieving, the main tactic of the poem is to offer joyous, pastoral nature images, frequently personified—the lambs dancing as to the tabor, the moon looking about her in the sky. But when the poet attains the philosophic mind and his fullest realization about memory and imagination, he begins to employ far more subtle descriptions of nature that, rather than jauntily imposing humanity upon natural objects, simply draw human characteristics out of their natural presences, referring back to human qualities from earlier in the poem.

So, in the final stanza, the brooks “fret” down their channels, just as the child's mother “fretted” him with kisses earlier in the poem; they trip lightly just as the speaker “tripped lightly” as a child; the Day is new-born, innocent, and bright, just as a child would be; the clouds “gather round the setting sun” and “take a sober coloring,” just as mourners at a funeral (recalling the child's playing with some fragment from “a mourning or a funeral” earlier in the poem) might gather soberly around a grave. The effect is to illustrate how, in the process of imaginative creativity possible to the mature mind, the shapes of humanity can be found in nature and vice-versa. (Recall the “music of humanity” in “Tintern Abbey.”) A flower can summon thoughts too deep for tears because a flower can embody the shape of human life, and it is the mind of maturity combined with the memory of childhood that enables the poet to make that vital and moving connection.

"Kubla Khan"

"Kubla Khan" is considered to be one of the greatest poems by the English Romantic poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge, who said he wrote the strange and hallucinatory poem shortly after waking up from an opium-influenced dream in 1797. In the first part of the poem, the speaker envisions the landscape surrounding the Mongol ruler and Chinese emperor Kubla Khan's summer palace, called "Xanadu," describing it as a place of beauty, pleasure, and violence. The speaker suggests that these qualities are all deeply intertwined and, in the final stanza, announces a desire to build a "pleasure palace" of the speaker's own through song. The poem is one of Coleridge's most famous, and has been interpreted in many different ways. Overall, though, it's possible to think of it as speaking to the creative ambitions of poetry itself—as well as to its limitations.

Summary

The speaker describes the “stately pleasure-dome” built in Xanadu according to the decree of Kubla Khan, in the place where Alph, the sacred river, ran “through caverns measureless to man / Down to a sunless sea.” Walls and towers were raised around “twice five miles of fertile ground,” filled with beautiful gardens and forests. A “deep romantic chasm” slanted down a green hill, occasionally spewing forth a violent and powerful burst of water, so great that it flung boulders up with it “like rebounding hail.” The river ran five miles through the woods, finally sinking “in tumult to a lifeless ocean.” Amid that tumult, in the place “as holy and enchanted / As e’er beneath a waning moon was haunted / By woman wailing to her demon-lover,” Kubla heard “ancestral voices” bringing prophesies of war. The pleasure-dome’s shadow floated on the waves, where the mingled sounds of the fountain and the caves could be heard. “It was a miracle of rare device,” the speaker says, “A sunny pleasure-dome with caves of ice!”

The speaker says that he once saw a “damsel with a dulcimer,” an Abyssinian maid who played her dulcimer and sang “of Mount Abora.” He says that if he could revive “her symphony and song” within him, he would rebuild the pleasure-dome out of music, and all who heard him would cry “Beware!” of “His flashing eyes, his floating hair!” The hearers would circle him thrice and close their eyes with “holy dread,” knowing that he had tasted honeydew, “and drunk the milk of Paradise.”

Form

The chant-like, musical incantations of “Kubla Khan” result from Coleridge’s masterful use of iambic tetrameter and alternating rhyme schemes. The first stanza is written in tetrameter with a rhyme scheme of ABAABCCDEDE, alternating between staggered rhymes and couplets. The second stanza expands into tetrameter and follows roughly the same rhyming pattern, also expanded—ABAABCCDDFFGGHIIHJJ. The third stanza tightens into tetrameter and rhymes ABABCC. The fourth stanza continues the tetrameter of the third and rhymes ABCCBDEDEFGFFFGHHG.

Commentary

Along with “The Rime of the Ancient Mariner,” “Kubla Khan” is one of Coleridge’s most famous and enduring poems. The story of its composition is also one of the most famous in the history of English poetry. As the poet explains in the short preface to this poem, he had fallen asleep after taking “an anodyne” prescribed “in consequence of a slight disposition” (this is a euphemism for opium, to which Coleridge was known to be addicted). Before falling asleep, he had been reading a story in which Kubla Khan commanded the building of a new palace; Coleridge claims that while he slept, he had a fantastic vision and composed

simultaneously—while sleeping—some two or three hundred lines of poetry, “if that indeed can be called composition in which all the images rose up before him as things, with a parallel production of the correspondent expressions, without any sensation or conscious effort.”

Waking after about three hours, the poet seized a pen and began writing furiously; however, after copying down the first three stanzas of his dreamt poem—the first three stanzas of the current poem as we know it—he was interrupted by a “person on business from Porlock,” who detained him for an hour. After this interruption, he was unable to recall the rest of the vision or the poetry he had composed in his opium dream. It is thought that the final stanza of the poem, thematizing the idea of the lost vision through the figure of the “damsel with a dulcimer” and the milk of Paradise, was written post-interruption. The mysterious person from Porlock is one of the most notorious and enigmatic figures in Coleridge’s biography; no one knows who he was or why he disturbed the poet or what he wanted or, indeed, whether any of Coleridge’s story is actually true. But the person from Porlock has become a metaphor for the malicious interruptions the world throws in the way of inspiration and genius, and “Kubla Khan,” strange and ambiguous as it is, has become what is perhaps the definitive statement on the obstruction and thwarting of the visionary genius.

Regrettably, the story of the poem’s composition, while thematically rich in and of itself, often overshadows the poem proper, which is one of Coleridge’s most haunting and beautiful. The first three stanzas are products of pure imagination: The pleasure-dome of Kubla Khan is not a useful metaphor for anything in particular (though in the context of the poem’s history, it becomes a metaphor for the unbuilt monument of imagination); however, it is a fantastically prodigious

descriptive act. The poem becomes especially evocative when, after the second stanza, the meter suddenly tightens; the resulting lines are terse and solid, almost beating out the sound of the war drums (“The shadow of the dome of pleasure / Floated midway on the waves...”).

The fourth stanza states the theme of the poem as a whole (though “Kubla Khan” is almost impossible to consider as a unified whole, as its parts are so sharply divided). The speaker says that he once had a vision of the damsel singing of Mount Abora; this vision becomes a metaphor for Coleridge’s vision of the 300-hundred-line masterpiece he never completed. The speaker insists that if he could only “revive” within him “her symphony and song,” he would recreate the pleasure-dome out of music and words, and take on the persona of the magician or visionary. His hearers would recognize the dangerous power of the vision, which would manifest itself in his “flashing eyes” and “floating hair.” But, awestruck, they would nonetheless dutifully take part in the ritual, recognizing that “he on honey-dew hath fed, / And drunk the milk of Paradise.”

“Dejection: An Ode”

Summary

The speaker recalls a poem that tells the tale of Sir Patrick Spence: In this poem, the moon takes on a certain strange appearance that presages the coming of a storm. The speaker declares that if the author of the poem possessed a sound understanding of weather, then a storm will break on this night as well, for the moon looks now as it did in the poem. The speaker wishes ardently for a storm to erupt, for the violence of the squall might cure his numb feeling. He says that he feels only a ‘dull pain,’ “a grief without a pang”—a constant deadening of all his feelings. Speaking to a woman whom he addresses as “O Lady,” he admits that he

has been gazing at the western sky all evening, able to see its beauty but unable fully to feel it. He says that staring at the green sky will never raise his spirits, for no “outward forms” can generate feelings: Emotions can only emerge from within.

According to the speaker, “we receive but what we give”: the soul itself must provide the light by which we may hope to see nature’s true beauty—a beauty not given to the common crowd of human beings (“the poor loveless ever-anxious crowd”). Calling the Lady “pure of heart,” the speaker says that she already knows about the light and music of the soul, which is Joy. Joy, he says, marries us to nature, thereby giving us “a new Earth and new Heaven, / Undreamt of by the sensual and the proud.”

The speaker insists that there was a time when he was full of hope, when every tribulation was simply the material with which “fancy made me dreams of happiness.” But now his afflictions press him to the earth; he does not mind the decline of his mirth, but he cannot bear the corresponding degeneration of his imagination, which is the source of his creativity and his understanding of the human condition, that which enables him to construct “from my own nature all the natural man.” Hoping to escape the “viper thoughts” that coil around his mind, the speaker turns his attention to the howling wind that has begun to blow. He thinks of the world as an instrument played by a musician, who spins out of the wind a “worse than wintry song.” This melody first calls to mind the rush of an army on the field; quieting, it then evokes a young girl, lost and alone.

It is midnight, but the speaker has “small thoughts” of sleep. However, he hopes that his friend the Lady will be visited by “gentle Sleep” and that she will wake

with joyful thoughts and “light heart.” Calling the Lady the “friend devoutest of my choice,” the speaker wishes that she might “ever, ever more rejoice.”

Form

The long ode stanzas of “Dejection” are metered in iambic lines ranging in length from trimeter to pentameter. The rhymes alternate between bracketed rhymes (ABBA) and couplets (CC) with occasional exceptions.

Commentary

In this poem, Coleridge continues his sophisticated philosophical exploration of the relationship between man and nature, positing as he did in “The Nightingale” that human feelings and the forms of nature are essentially separate. Just as the speaker insisted in the earlier poem that the nightingale’s song should not be called melancholy simply because it sounded so to a melancholy poet, he insists here that the beauty of the sky before the storm does not have the power to fill him with joy, for the source of human feeling is within. Only when the individual has access to that source, so that joy shines from him like a light, is he able to see the beauty of nature and to respond to it. (As in “Frost in Midnight,” the city-raised Coleridge insists on a sharper demarcation between the mind and nature than the country-raised Wordsworth would ever have done.)

Coleridge blames his desolate numbness for sapping his creative powers and leaving him without his habitual method of understanding human nature. Despite his insistence on the separation between the mind and the world, Coleridge nevertheless continues to find metaphors for his own feelings in nature: His dejection is reflected in the gloom of the night as it awaits the storm.

“Dejection” was written in 1802 but was originally drafted in the form of a letter to Sara Hutchinson, the woman Coleridge loved. The much longer original version of the poem contained many of the same elements as “The Nightingale” and “Frost at Midnight,” including the same meditation on his children and their natural education. This version also referred explicitly to “Sara” (replaced in the later version by “Lady”) and “William” (a clear reference to Wordsworth). Coleridge’s strict revision process shortened and tightened the poem, depersonalizing it, but the earlier draft hints at just how important the poem’s themes were to Coleridge personally and indicates that the feelings expressed were the poet’s true beliefs about his own place in the world.

A side note: The story of Sir Patrick Spence, to which the poet alludes in the first stanza, is an ancient Scottish ballad about a sailor who drowns with a boatload of Scottish noblemen, sailing on orders from the king but against his own better judgment. It contains lines that refer to the moon as a predictor of storms, which Coleridge quotes as an epigraph for his ode: “Late, late yestreen I saw the new Moon / With the old Moon in her arms; / And I fear, I fear, my Master dear! / We shall have a deadly storm.”

UNIT-3

Second Generation Romantics Lord George Gordon Noel Byron: *'Childe Harold': canto III, verses 36-45 (lines 316-405); [3] canto IV, verses 178-86 (1594- 674) [3]* **Percy Bysshe Shelley:** *` Ode to the West Wind'[2]131 ' Ozymandias' [2][3] `Hymn to Intellectual Beauty[3]* **John Keats:** *` Ode to a Nightingale' [2][3] `To Autumn' [2][3]*

Lord Byron's Poems Summary and Analysis of Childe Harold's Pilgrimage, Canto III

The third canto of *Childe Harold's Pilgrimage* continues the travelogue framework of the first two cantos, self-aware that Byron is beginning something of a sequel to the original publication of just the first two cantos. This time, the muse is Ada, Childe Harold is older, and his journey is from Dover to Waterloo, then following the Rhine River into Switzerland. Harold is still independent, “proud though in desolation,” nature being his favored companion on his travels, the world of men and war being relatively distasteful.

Waterloo inspires Byron's consideration of battlefields and the bloodshed and wasted upon them; he contrasts violence in the name of aggression with the struggles of oppressed people for liberty. He particularly cites the heroism of the Hon. Major Frederick Howard (who died in battle and was disinterred and repatriated to England in 1816), and turns to consider the thousands of others who died. The poet dwells on sorrow and remembrance for many stanzas, then meditates upon the nature of human genius and the desire for greatness—and on Napoleon, who drew so many others into his battles. The death of a man in battle ought to “unteach mankind the lust to shine or rule” (stanza 43). And what does fame bring one in future ages except an extra page in the history books, and “an ornamented grave” (stanza 48)?

Harold spends time considering that there is still someone he loves, despite his general distaste for others. Then, back to his travels, Harold is in Switzerland, where he extols the bravery of General François-Séverin Marceau-Desgraviers, who died in battle at age 27 fighting for France's “rights” (stanza 56), and then visits the majestic Alps in all their “cold sublimity,” far above mankind (stanza 62). And in contrast to Waterloo, which was about power, “true Glory's stainless

victories” were accomplished in the name of liberty in the 15th-century battle of Morat and the ancient battle of Marathon (stanza 64). The names of the brave “must not wither” (stanza 67).

In stanzas 69-75, the poet digresses to defend the spirit of individualism, arguing that “to fly from, need not be to hate, mankind,” and that the deep thinker is merely avoiding the unproductive situations where people entangle themselves in battles of “wretched interchange of wrong for wrong / Midst a contentious world.” The poet would choose nature over the problems of “the rushing crowd.” Contemplating his own death, he chooses to live seeking “the Spirit of each spot” (stanza 74). The poet returns to his main subject, contemplating Jean-Jacques Rousseau, the political philosopher from Geneva, while he is at Lake Lemman (Lake Geneva). Rousseau is another man misunderstood by the “vulgar minds” of his contemporaries (stanza 79).

Overarching this scene, with Rousseau in the background, is Nature, an amoral force for both beauty and danger. The natural world and its laws become the “great equalizer” among men, as nature demonstrates her power in the storm and earthquake while men hide in fear. However, Nature also can be seen as the works and struggles of men writ large, and so is connected to, if separate from, human life.

The canto concludes with the poet invoking his muse, who regretfully is not physically present with him on his travels.

Analysis

Byron opens and closes Canto III by addressing his absent daughter (she was taken by his wife when she left him). This apostrophe indicates Byron’s sense of loss and

isolation in being bereft of his beloved daughter, and by extension the family of which she was a part and the union between himself and the former Lady Byron. Annabella Byron had already left her husband, taking their young daughter with them, and asked for a separation on the grounds that Byron was either insane or cruel. After much cajoling on the part of the poet, he finally agreed to it. By this time the English media was spreading rumors of infidelity, violence, and incest on Byron's part, going so far as to call for his exile. In 1816 Byron left England, never to return. In so leaving, he also abandoned any reasonable hope of seeing his daughter again. One can see from this biography why this canto features a man traveling and turning his back on the conflicts in the world.

Besides crying out in self-pity, Byron also subtly calls upon his daughter Ada as his muse for Canto III. She will be his inspiration as he describes the battlefields and men of greatness who are the subject of this canto. At the same time, Byron does not hide Ada's identity under a pseudonym as he did in the first two cantos; he is now ready to erase the line separating himself and the fictional "Childe Harold" completely by making this canto entirely autobiographical and expressive of his own political and philosophical beliefs in no uncertain terms. Harold is hardly mentioned.

Byron takes up several themes in Canto III. The first is the sense of isolation, brought to the fore by his apostrophe to his daughter Ada. Isolation pervades the poem by accentuating the other themes: the misunderstanding of genius, freedom from despotism, and the value of Nature. Byron remarks on two great men of genius in Canto III, Napoleon and Rousseau. He suggests that both men continue to be misunderstood by their inferiors. Although Byron does not condone Napoleon's attempt at tyranny, he nonetheless maintains an objective admiration for the man's accomplishments and vision. France had "rights," and

Byron extols the bravery of one young man who fought for France's rights against the coalition of nations that were trying to suppress France's power in the late 18th century. As for Rousseau, while he expresses concern that some of Rousseau's ideas were deluded, Byron acknowledges that the man was full of passion and drive beyond the scope of most men. Byron describes these giants in their different spheres as "madmen who have made men mad / By their contagion," indicating the power of their presence and also their ability to influence others as a part of their greatness.

Byron supplements his admiration of Napoleon and Rousseau with his recurring theme of liberty. On visiting the battlefields of Waterloo and Morat, Byron sadly reflects that the defeat of a tyrant is not the same thing as a defeat of all tyranny. Byron contrasts Waterloo, a battle fought for aggression, with Morat, a battle fought by the Swiss to defend their liberty against the Burgundians in the 16th century. Waterloo will be remembered as merely bloody—to Byron, no war of aggression could be justified—whereas Morat was, to Byron, a justifiable battle in that it was undertaken in the defense of liberty. Byron couples Morat with the Greek battle of Marathon as "true Glory's stainless victories."

When Byron's journey takes him to Lake Lemman and the Alps, his poetry turns to the wonders of Nature and puts Rousseau in his natural Genevan context. Unlike Wordsworth, who saw Nature as something separate from and superior to man, wherein a person could experience purity and perfection and thus improve himself, Byron saw Nature as a magnification of man's—particularly his own—greatness and follies. To Byron, Nature was not an escape from his problems, but a vast landscape of reminders. Vast glaciers, thundering avalanches, and wild storms only accentuated Byron's own internal struggles and reminded him how dangerous and marvelous a piece of work is man. The Alps express the Romantic theme of

the sublime, those things that awe man by being too large to fully comprehend, somewhat as a genius might seem to the vulgar.

Canto III, written several years after the first two cantos, is clearly the product of a more fully developed poetic sensibility, and the early stanzas make it clear that Byron knows he is writing something of a sequel. Byron has returned to his focus on realism after several forays into shorter, lighter verse, and has come back to it as a more seasoned architect of words. In many ways, Canto III is a different poem entirely from that of Cantos I and II; it is mainly the form of the poetic travelogue and the overarching themes of liberty, isolation, and individualism that connect these disparate works together.

Percy Bysshe Shelley: ` Ode to the West Wind

Summary

The speaker invokes the “wild West Wind” of autumn, which scatters the dead leaves and spreads seeds so that they may be nurtured by the spring, and asks that the wind, a “destroyer and preserver,” hear him. The speaker calls the wind the “dirge / Of the dying year,” and describes how it stirs up violent storms, and again implores it to hear him. The speaker says that the wind stirs the Mediterranean from “his summer dreams,” and cleaves the Atlantic into choppy chasms, making the “sapless foliage” of the ocean tremble, and asks for a third time that it hear him. The speaker says that if he were a dead leaf that the wind could bear, or a cloud it could carry, or a wave it could push, or even if he were, as a boy, “the comrade” of the wind’s “wandering over heaven,” then he would never have needed to pray to the wind and invoke its powers. He pleads with the wind to lift him “as a wave, a leaf, a cloud!”—for though he is like the wind at heart, untamable and proud—he is now chained and bowed with the weight of his hours upon the earth. The speaker asks the wind to “make me thy lyre,” to be his own

Spirit, and to drive his thoughts across the universe, “like withered leaves, to quicken a new birth.” He asks the wind, by the incantation of this verse, to scatter his words among mankind, to be the “trumpet of a prophecy.” Speaking both in regard to the season and in regard to the effect upon mankind that he hopes his words to have, the speaker asks: “If winter comes, can spring be far behind?”

Form

Each of the seven parts of “Ode to the West Wind” contains five stanzas—four three-line stanzas and a two-line couplet, all metered in iambic pentameter. The rhyme scheme in each part follows a pattern known as *terza rima*, the three-line rhyme scheme employed by Dante in his *Divine Comedy*. In the three-line *terza rima* stanza, the first and third lines rhyme, and the middle line does not; then the end sound of that middle line is employed as the rhyme for the first and third lines in the next stanza. The final couplet rhymes with the middle line of the last three-line stanza. Thus each of the seven parts of “Ode to the West Wind” follows this scheme: ABA BCB CDC DED EE.

Commentary

The wispy, fluid *terza rima* of “Ode to the West Wind” finds Shelley taking a long thematic leap beyond the scope of “Hymn to Intellectual Beauty,” and incorporating his own art into his meditation on beauty and the natural world. Shelley invokes the wind magically, describing its power and its role as both “destroyer and preserver,” and asks the wind to sweep him out of his torpor “as a wave, a leaf, a cloud!” In the fifth section, the poet then takes a remarkable turn, transforming the wind into a metaphor for his own art, the expressive capacity that drives “dead thoughts” like “withered leaves” over the universe, to “quicken a new birth”—that is, to quicken the coming of the spring. Here the spring season is a

metaphor for a “spring” of human consciousness, imagination, liberty, or morality—all the things Shelley hoped his art could help to bring about in the human mind. Shelley asks the wind to be his spirit, and in the same movement he makes it his metaphorical spirit, his poetic faculty, which will play him like a musical instrument, the way the wind strums the leaves of the trees. The thematic implication is significant: whereas the older generation of Romantic poets viewed nature as a source of truth and authentic experience, the younger generation largely viewed nature as a source of beauty and aesthetic experience. In this poem, Shelley explicitly links nature with art by finding powerful natural metaphors with which to express his ideas about the power, import, quality, and ultimate effect of aesthetic expression.

"Hymn to Intellectual Beauty"

Summary

The speaker says that the shadow of an invisible Power floats among human beings, occasionally visiting human hearts—manifested in summer winds, or moonbeams, or the memory of music, or anything that is precious for its mysterious grace. Addressing this Spirit of Beauty, the speaker asks where it has gone, and why it leaves the world so desolate when it goes—why human hearts can feel such hope and love when it is present, and such despair and hatred when it is gone. He asserts that religious and superstitious notions—“Demon, Ghost, and Heaven”—are nothing more than the attempts of mortal poets and wise men to explain and express their responses to the Spirit of Beauty, which alone, the speaker says, can give “grace and truth to life’s unquiet dream.” Love, Hope, and Self-Esteem come and go at the whim of the Spirit, and if it would only stay in the human heart forever, instead of coming and going unpredictably, man would be “immortal and omnipotent.” The Spirit inspires lovers and nourishes thought; and

the speaker implores the spirit to remain even after his life has ended, fearing that without it death will be “a dark reality.”

The speaker recalls that when he was a boy, he “sought for ghosts,” and traveled through caves and forests looking for “the departed dead”; but only when the Spirit’s shadow fell across him—as he mused “deeply on the lot / Of life” outdoors in the spring—did he experience transcendence. At that moment, he says, “I shrieked, and clasped my hands in ecstasy!” He then vowed that he would dedicate his life to the Spirit of Beauty; now he asserts that he has kept his vow—every joy he has ever had has been linked to the hope that the “awful Loveliness” would free the world from slavery, and complete the articulation of his words. The speaker observes that after noon the day becomes “more solemn and serene,” and in autumn there is a “lustre in the sky” which cannot be found in summer. The speaker asks the Spirit, whose power descended upon his youth like that truth of nature, to supply “calm” to his “onward life”—the life of a man who worships the Spirit and every form that contains it, and who is bound by the spells of the Spirit to “fear himself, and love all humankind.”

Form

Each of the seven long stanzas of the “Hymn to Intellectual Beauty” follows the same, highly regular scheme. Each line has an iambic rhythm; the first four lines of each stanza are written in pentameter, the fifth line in hexameter, the sixth, seventh, eighth, ninth, tenth, and eleventh lines in tetrameter, and the twelfth line in pentameter. (The syllable pattern for each stanza, then, is 555564444445.) Each stanza is rhymed ABBAACCBDDDEE.

Commentary

This lyric hymn, written in 1816, is Shelley's earliest focused attempt to incorporate the Romantic ideal of communion with nature into his own aesthetic philosophy. The "Intellectual Beauty" of the poem's title does not refer to the beauty of the mind or of the working intellect, but rather to the intellectual idea of beauty, abstracted in this poem to the "Spirit of Beauty," whose shadow comes and goes over human hearts. The poem is the poet's exploration both of the qualities of beauty (here it always resides in nature, for example), and of the qualities of the human being's response to it ("Love, Hope, and Self-esteem").

The poem's process is doubly figurative or associative, in that, once the poet abstracts the metaphor of the Spirit from the particulars of natural beauty, he then explains the workings of this Spirit by comparing it back to the very particulars of natural beauty from which it was abstracted in the first place: "Thy light alone, *like* mist o'er mountains driven"; "Love, Hope, and Self-esteem, *like* clouds depart..." This is an inspired technique, for it enables Shelley to illustrate the stunning experience of natural beauty time and again as the poem progresses, but to push the particulars into the background, so that the focus of the poem is always on the Spirit, the abstract intellectual ideal that the speaker claims to serve.

Of course Shelley's atheism is a famous part of his philosophical stance, so it may seem strange that he has written a hymn of any kind. He addresses that strangeness in the third stanza, when he declares that names such as "Demon, Ghost, and Heaven" are merely the record of attempts by sages to explain the effect of the Spirit of Beauty—but that the effect has never been explained by any "voice from some sublimer world." The Spirit of Beauty that the poet worships is not supernatural, it is a part of the world. It is not an independent entity; it is a responsive capability within the poet's own mind.

If the “Hymn to Intellectual Beauty” is not among Shelley’s very greatest poems, it is only because its project falls short of the poet’s extraordinary powers; simply drawing the abstract ideal of his own experience of beauty and declaring his fidelity to that ideal seems too simple a task for Shelley. His most important statements on natural beauty and on aesthetics will take into account a more complicated idea of his own connection to nature as an expressive artist and a poet, as we shall see in “To a Skylark” and “Ode to the West Wind.” Nevertheless, the “Hymn” remains an important poem from the early period of Shelley’s maturity. It shows him working to incorporate Wordsworthian ideas of nature, in some ways the most important theme of early Romanticism, into his own poetic project, and, by connecting his idea of beauty to his idea of human religion, making that theme explicitly his own.

Summary and Analysis Hymn to Intellectual Beauty

Summary

The shadow of a strange power floats unseen throughout the world, entering into man, coming and going mysteriously. Shelley asks this shadow, which he calls a "Spirit of Beauty," where it has gone and why it disappears and leaves us desolate. Then he acknowledges that it is vain to ask this question; one might as well ask why rainbows disappear or why man can both love and hate, despair and hope. No voice from another world has ever answered these questions. The "names of Demon, Ghost, and Heaven" are the record of men's vain attempts to get answers to such questions. Only the light of the Spirit of Beauty gives grace and truth to the restless dream which life is. If the Spirit of Beauty remained constantly with man, man would be immortal and omnipotent. It nourishes human thought. The poet

beseeches this spirit not to depart from the world. Without it, death would be an experience to be feared.

When Shelley was a boy, he sought spiritual reality in ghosts and the dead. In his search, the shadow of the Spirit of Beauty suddenly fell on him and filled him with elation. He vowed that he would dedicate himself to this Spirit and he has kept his vow. He is convinced that it will free the world from the state of slavery in which it is. He prays that this power will bring calm to his life, for he worships it. It has taught him to fear himself and love all mankind.

Analysis

The "Hymn to Intellectual Beauty" was conceived and written during a boating excursion with Byron on Lake Geneva, Switzerland, in June 1816. The beauty of the lake and of the Swiss Alps is responsible for Shelley's elevating what he calls "Intellectual Beauty" to the ruling principle of the universe.

Ode to a Nightingale

Summary

As an ode, the poem pays homage to the nightingale but also appreciates the beauty of nature, which is characteristic of Romantic poetry. The speaker believes that the perfection of nature, and its beauty, is manifested in the bird, which is not man-made and, therefore, is pure and uncorrupted. The tone of the poem rejects the optimistic pursuit of pleasure found within Keats's earlier poems and, instead, explores the themes of nature, transience and mortality, the latter being particularly relevant to Keats. The nightingale described experiences a type of death but does not actually die.

Summary

The speaker opens with a declaration of his own heartache. He feels numb, as though he had taken a drug only a moment ago. He is addressing a nightingale he hears singing somewhere in the forest and says that his “drowsy numbness” is not from envy of the nightingale’s happiness, but rather from sharing it too completely; he is “too happy” that the nightingale sings the music of summer from amid some unseen plot of green trees and shadows. In the second stanza, the speaker longs for the oblivion of alcohol, expressing his wish for wine, “a draught of vintage,” that would taste like the country and like peasant dances, and let him “leave the world unseen” and disappear into the dim forest with the nightingale. In the third stanza, he explains his desire to fade away, saying he would like to forget the troubles the nightingale has never known: “the weariness, the fever, and the fret” of human life, with its consciousness that everything is mortal and nothing lasts. Youth “grows pale, and spectre-thin, and dies,” and “beauty cannot keep her lustrous eyes.”

In the fourth stanza, the speaker tells the nightingale to fly away, and he will follow, not through alcohol (“Not charioted by Bacchus and his pards”), but through poetry, which will give him “viewless wings.” He says he is already with the nightingale and describes the forest glade, where even the moonlight is hidden by the trees, except the light that breaks through when the breezes blow the branches. In the fifth stanza, the speaker says that he cannot see the flowers in the glade, but can guess them “in embalmed darkness”: white Hawthorne, eglantine, violets, and the musk-rose, “the murmurous haunt of flies on summer eves.” In the sixth stanza, the speaker listens in the dark to the nightingale, saying that he has often been “half in love” with the idea of dying and called Death soft names in many rhymes. Surrounded by the nightingale’s song, the speaker thinks that the

idea of death seems richer than ever, and he longs to “cease upon the midnight with no pain” while the nightingale pours its soul ecstatically forth. If he were to die, the nightingale would continue to sing, he says, but he would “have ears in vain” and be no longer able to hear.

Psyche,” which has the loosest structure of all the odes). Each stanza in “Nightingale” is rhymed ABABCDECDE, Keats’s most basic scheme throughout the odes.

Analysis

With “Ode to a Nightingale,” Keats’s speaker begins his fullest and deepest exploration of the themes of creative expression and the mortality of human life. In this ode, the transience of life and the tragedy of old age (“where palsy shakes a few, sad, last gray hairs, / Where youth grows pale, and spectre-thin, and dies”) is set against the eternal renewal of the nightingale’s fluid music (“Thou wast not born for death, immortal bird!”). The speaker reprises the “drowsy numbness” he experienced in “Ode on Indolence,” but where in “Indolence” that numbness was a sign of disconnection from experience, in “Nightingale” it is a sign of too full a connection: “being too happy in thine happiness,” as the speaker tells the nightingale. Hearing the song of the nightingale, the speaker longs to flee the human world and join the bird. His first thought is to reach the bird’s state through alcohol—in the second stanza, he longs for a “draught of vintage” to transport him out of himself. But after his meditation in the third stanza on the transience of life, he rejects the idea of being “charioted by Bacchus and his pards” (Bacchus was the Roman god of wine and was supposed to have been carried by a chariot pulled by leopards) and chooses instead to embrace, for the first time since he refused to follow the figures in “Indolence,” “the viewless wings of Poesy.”

The rapture of poetic inspiration matches the endless creative rapture of the nightingale's music and lets the speaker, in stanzas five through seven, imagine himself with the bird in the darkened forest. The ecstatic music even encourages the speaker to embrace the idea of dying, of painlessly succumbing to death while enraptured by the nightingale's music and never experiencing any further pain or disappointment. But when his meditation causes him to utter the word "forlorn," he comes back to himself, recognizing his fancy for what it is—an imagined escape from the inescapable ("Adieu! the fancy cannot cheat so well / As she is fam'd to do, deceiving elf"). As the nightingale flies away, the intensity of the speaker's experience has left him shaken, unable to remember whether he is awake or asleep.

In "Indolence," the speaker rejected all artistic effort. In "Psyche," he was willing to embrace the creative imagination, but only for its own internal pleasures. But in the nightingale's song, he finds a form of outward expression that translates the work of the imagination into the outside world, and this is the discovery that compels him to embrace Poesy's "viewless wings" at last. The "art" of the nightingale is endlessly changeable and renewable; it is music without record, existing only in a perpetual present. As befits his celebration of music, the speaker's language, sensually rich though it is, serves to suppress the sense of sight in favor of the other senses. He can imagine the light of the moon, "But here there is no light"; he knows he is surrounded by flowers, but he "cannot see what flowers" are at his feet. This suppression will find its match in "Ode on a Grecian Urn," which is in many ways a companion poem to "Ode to a Nightingale." In the later poem, the speaker will finally confront a created art-object not subject to any of the limitations of time; in "Nightingale," he has achieved creative expression and has placed his faith in it, but that expression—the nightingale's song—is spontaneous and without physical manifestation.

'To Autumn':

summary This poem narrates the passing of both a glorious autumn day and the season itself. The poem begins with Keats addressing autumn as a personified figure and describing its abundance and richness. He notes the presence of fruit and harvest, and the sounds of animals preparing for winter.

Summary

Keats's speaker opens his first stanza by addressing Autumn, describing its abundance and its intimacy with the sun, with whom Autumn ripens fruits and causes the late flowers to bloom. In the second stanza, the speaker describes the figure of Autumn as a female goddess, often seen sitting on the granary floor, her hair "soft-lifted" by the wind, and often seen sleeping in the fields or watching a cider-press squeezing the juice from apples. In the third stanza, the speaker tells Autumn not to wonder where the songs of spring have gone, but instead to listen to her own music. At twilight, the "small gnats" hum among the "the river sallows," or willow trees, lifted and dropped by the wind, and "full-grown lambs" bleat from the hills, crickets sing, robins whistle from the garden, and swallows, gathering for their coming migration, sing from the skies.

Form

Like the "Ode on Melancholy," "To Autumn" is written in a three-stanza structure with a variable rhyme scheme. Each stanza is eleven lines long (as opposed to ten in "Melancholy"), and each is metered in a relatively precise iambic pentameter. In terms of both thematic organization and rhyme scheme, each stanza is divided roughly into two parts. In each stanza, the first part is made up of the first four lines of the stanza, and the second part is made up of the last seven lines. The first

part of each stanza follows an ABAB rhyme scheme, the first line rhyming with the third, and the second line rhyming with the fourth. The second part of each stanza is longer and varies in rhyme scheme: The first stanza is arranged CDEDCCE, and the second and third stanzas are arranged CDECDDE. (Thematically, the first part of each stanza serves to define the subject of the stanza, and the second part offers room for musing, development, and speculation on that subject; however, this thematic division is only very general.)

Analysis

In both its form and descriptive surface, “To Autumn” is one of the simplest of Keats’s odes. There is nothing confusing or complex in Keats’s paean to the season of autumn, with its fruitfulness, its flowers, and the song of its swallows gathering for migration. The extraordinary achievement of this poem lies in its ability to suggest, explore, and develop a rich abundance of themes without ever ruffling its calm, gentle, and lovely description of autumn. Where “Ode on Melancholy” presents itself as a strenuous heroic quest, “To Autumn” is concerned with the much quieter activity of daily observation and appreciation. In this quietude, the gathered themes of the preceding odes find their fullest and most beautiful expression.

“To Autumn” takes up where the other odes leave off. Like the others, it shows Keats’s speaker paying homage to a particular goddess—in this case, the deified season of Autumn. The selection of this season implicitly takes up the other odes’ themes of temporality, mortality, and change: Autumn in Keats’s ode is a time of warmth and plenty, but it is perched on the brink of winter’s desolation, as the bees enjoy “later flowers,” the harvest is gathered from the fields, the lambs of spring are now “full grown,” and, in the final line of the poem, the swallows gather for

their winter migration. The understated sense of inevitable loss in that final line makes it one of the most moving moments in all of poetry; it can be read as a simple, uncomplaining summation of the entire human condition.

Despite the coming chill of winter, the late warmth of autumn provides Keats's speaker with ample beauty to celebrate: the cottage and its surroundings in the first stanza, the agrarian haunts of the goddess in the second, and the locales of natural creatures in the third. Keats's speaker is able to experience these beauties in a sincere and meaningful way because of the lessons he has learned in the previous odes: He is no longer indolent, no longer committed to the isolated imagination (as in "Psyche"), no longer attempting to escape the pain of the world through ecstatic rapture (as in "Nightingale"), no longer frustrated by the attempt to eternalize mortal beauty or subject eternal beauty to time (as in "Urn"), and no longer able to frame the connection of pleasure and the sorrow of loss only as an imaginary heroic quest (as in "Melancholy").

In "To Autumn," the speaker's experience of beauty refers back to earlier odes (the swallows recall the nightingale; the fruit recalls joy's grape; the goddess drowsing among the poppies recalls Psyche and Cupid lying in the grass), but it also recalls a wealth of earlier poems. Most importantly, the image of Autumn winnowing and harvesting (in a sequence of odes often explicitly about creativity) recalls an earlier Keats poem in which the activity of harvesting is an explicit metaphor for artistic creation.

On First Looking into Chapman's Homer

On First Looking into Chapman's Homer is about Keats' venture into the reading of Chapman's translations of Homer. He is overly excited about his new-found

knowledge and as a poet of experience and occasion, he writes about it as most of the Romantics used to do – express their feelings or moments.

Summary in one go:

On First Looking into Chapman's Homer is about Keats' venture into the reading of Chapman's translations of Homer. He is overly excited about his new-found knowledge and as a poet of experience and occasion, he writes about it as most of the Romantics used to do – express their feelings or moments. Keats thinks that reading Chapman has given him a distinct treasure and this wonderful wealth has been kept from him until he read Chapman. He compares himself with the overjoyed scientist who finds out about a new planet to see his name immortalised on the pages of history or a sailor (adventurer) who finds out new places for the sections of people.

Analysis:

The poem is one of the finest Petrarchan sonnets ever composed! It follows the rhyme scheme a b b a a b b a – c d c d c d. Without going into the history and usual spying which most of the other scholars do, I have very limited points to make. This is one of the earliest poems Keats composed and yet it has superior qualities. A usual romantic poem in tone and content, the poem is about the fanciful exploration of a new world – the world of Greek legends and it formed the base of many of the later poems that Keats wrote. However, Keats had wonderfully confused (though scholars hint that it might be a mistake but I don't take that argument) Cortes with Balboa who was the actual person who first found the Pacific. For Keats, the only religion was beauty and this beauty also peeps through his lines. While composing poems, he reached from place to place like a wild soul and he never cared for the factual correctness because it might mar the effect of imagination; imagination is inherently wild and an uncontrolled beast which can

seldom be reined and those who rein it can seldom imagine! On First Looking into Chapman's Home remains in front of us as an example of the same – imagination at its best! Just by reading Chapman, Keats found himself dip in the mythology of the Greeks and he could not come out of it! And this poem is the testimony to this truth about him.

So, the article thus ends and I hope it has worked the purpose you would have wanted it to. Let me know more in the comments section and I will be more than happy to answer those questions or clarify the concerns or accept the corrections. :)

UNIT-4

Romantic Fiction Mary Shelley: Frankenstein²¹[3]

Frankenstein Summary and Analysis of Chapters 21-24

Chapter 21:

Victor is brought before the magistrate, and several witnesses testify against him. A crew of local fishermen found the victim, a young man of about twenty-five years of age. When Victor hears that the victim was strangled, he trembles with anxiety; this, he knows, is his creature's preferred *modus operandi*.

Seeing Frankenstein's agitation, Mr. Kirwin, the magistrate, suggest that Victor be shown the body, so that the tribunal might judge his reaction. Frankenstein is well composed as they conduct him toward the room in which the body has been laid; he has an unassailable alibi for the time that the body was found. When he walks into the chamber, he is overcome with horror: the lifeless form of Henry Clerval lies before him. Frankenstein throws himself upon the body, and becomes almost mad with grief and guilt; he is carried from the room in convulsions.

For two months, Victor lies in a delirium of fever and confusion. He cries out that he is a murderer, and begs his attendants to aid him in apprehending the monster.

He often imagines that he feels the hands of the monster closing about his neck, and starts from his bed in an agony of terror.

Victor longs for death, and finds his ability to survive such an epidemic of tragedies bitterly ironic. He concludes that he was, after all, "doomed to live."

When Victor finally emerges from his delirium, he finds that a grim-faced old woman has been attending upon his sickbed. She tells him that he will be sorely punished for the murder that he has committed, and would be better off dead; she seems to take pleasure in her own hatefulness and cruelty. The physician who is sent to examine Victor is equally careless and unfeeling. Victor bitterly reflects that now only the executioner is concerned with his well-being.

Frankenstein learns that Mr. Kirwin alone has shown him great kindness during his sickness; it is he who provided Victor with his sickroom and doctor. The magistrate visits him and expresses confidence that he will be cleared of all responsibility for the murder. He tells Victor that "a friend" has come to see him; thinking that it is the monster, Victor begs to have him sent away. Mr. Kirwin, much taken aback by this outburst, sternly informs him that the visitor is his father; at this, Victor is overjoyed.

He immediately asks after the safety of Elizabeth and Ernest, and the elder Frankenstein assures him they are all well. At the mention of Clerval, Victor weeps and exclaims that a horrid destiny hangs over his head.

His father's presence is "like that of a good angel" for Victor; slowly, he begins to regain his health. He often wishes that he were dead, but imagines that it is some dark force that keeps him alive, so that his evil destiny might be fulfilled.

Though Victor is cleared of all criminal charges, as "the cup of life [is] poisoned forever." His father tries in vain to cheer him, but Victor suffers from an insuperable melancholy. He is under constant observation, so as to keep him from taking his own life.

At length, Victor determines to triumph over "selfish despair," so that he might return to Geneva to protect his remaining family. Though the elder Frankenstein wishes to postpone the journey until his son has recovered from his melancholy, Victor will not be dissuaded. He cannot sleep without the aid of laudanum (a tranquilizer), and is frequently tormented by nightmares in which his creature strangles him.

Analysis:

There is a certain irony in Victor's being cleared of murder. On the one hand, he does bear some of the responsibility for Henry's death, insofar as it was he who created the monster; on the other, he was committing murder (of a kind) on the night in question. Recall that he was disposing of the female creation's remains at sea while the monster was strangling his friend. It might be said that Victor murdered that second creature; Henry's death can thus be regarded as his punishment for doing so.

The secret of the creature's existence is becoming too much for Victor to bear; he accuses himself of murder (albeit while in a semiconscious state) and tells his father that there is a nightmarish destiny that he has yet to fulfill. Victor longs to supersede the barrier of secrecy that has been erected between him and the rest of humanity. Here, we can see that he has forsaken his former selfishness: though he often longs for death, he forces himself to overcome this self-serving impulse in the hopes of keeping his surviving family from harm.

The death of Clerval serves as a symbol for the death of the last of Frankenstein's romantic idealism. It was Henry who helped to focus Victor's attentions on the world beyond the purview of science; it was he who enabled Victor to delight in the simple pleasures of nature. Victor is now deprived of even that joy, since he no longer has the privilege of seeing the world through Clerval's eyes. With each new murder, a piece of Frankenstein dies as well. He becomes increasingly broken, and is tormented by hysterical fits and fevers. Each of his attempts to withdraw into death or madness is thwarted, however: Victor is "doomed" to stay alive until his destiny has been completed.

Chapter 22:

Victor and his father are forced to stop in Paris, as Victor has grown too weak to continue the journey. The elder Frankenstein urges him to take solace in society. Victor, however, cannot bring himself to comply: the company of people is abhorrent to him. Though he is full of a great and indiscriminate love for humanity, feeling them to be "creatures of an angelic nature and celestial mechanism," he does not feel himself worthy of sharing in their intercourse. He has created a being who delights in bloodshed, and thus deserves only abhorrence and hatred.

Victor tells his father that he is the true engineer of all the catastrophes that have befallen them, but Alphonse attributes his confession to delirium. When his father begs him not to say such dreadful things, Victor replies that he would gladly have died in their place, but that he could not sacrifice all humankind to save those whom he loved. At length, Frankenstein is able (albeit through "the utmost self-violence") to control his desire to declare his guilt to the world.

He receives a letter from Elizabeth, who says that she is longing to see him. She expresses regret that he has suffered so terribly, and tells him that if his

unhappiness is related in any way to their impending marriage, she will gracefully leave him to the arms of another.

Victor is reminded of the creature's threat to be with him on his wedding night. He decides that if the creature succeeds in murdering him, he will at last be at peace; if, on the other hand, he triumphs, he will be able to enjoy both freedom and life with Elizabeth.

As Frankenstein wants desperately to please both Elizabeth and his father, he decides that he will not delay the marriage any longer than is necessary: after all, the creature has demonstrated, by the murder of Clerval, that he will not be kept from violence before the fateful wedding.

At Geneva, he finds Elizabeth much changed by all that is happened. She has lost the vivacity of her youth, but Victor regards her, in her new compassion and gentleness, as an even more fitting companion "for one so blasted and miserable" as he.

He often feels that he will succumb to madness; at these times, only Elizabeth can soothe him. Frankenstein promises her that he will reveal the reason for his misery on the day after their wedding.

His father urges him to let go of his unhappiness. Though their circle has grown small, it will be bound more closely together by mutual misfortune, and, in time "new objects of affection" will be born to replace what has been lost.

Victor and Elizabeth look forward to their union with both pleasure and apprehension. The necessary preparations are made, and the couple determines to honeymoon on the shores of Lake Como, in Italy. Victor takes a number of

precautions to protect both himself and his beloved; he becomes accustomed to carrying pistols and daggers about his person wherever he goes.

As the wedding-day approaches, the threat seems to be almost a delusion; Victor allows himself to believe that the marriage will actually take place, and that he will at last know happiness. Elizabeth seems cheerful, but is seized with melancholy on the day that the wedding is to take place. Victor now regards her sadness as a presentiment of evil, and imagines that she was apprehensive to discover the reason for his misery.

All is perfect on their wedding day. It is to be the last happy day in Victor's life. As they land on the shores of Como, both Elizabeth and Victor are overcome by a sense of inexplicable foreboding.

Analysis:

The hastiness of Victor's wedding is indicative of his frantic desire to create an illusion of order and tranquility for his family. The narrator vows not to "delay the moment a single hour." His urgency fills the reader with an almost unbearable apprehension, since we realize that Victor is hurtling toward the consummation of his horrible destiny. For Alphonse and Elizabeth (and even, to some extent, for Victor himself), the event appears to be a means of safeguarding the future. Elizabeth and Alphonse cling to the idea of the marriage as to a raft at sea; they hope to salvage something of happiness from the senseless and unrelenting tragedy.

Elizabeth, for her part, finds her joy commingled with an inexplicable foreboding of misfortune; in this way, Shelley foreshadows her doom. Victor seems to have temporarily lost the ability to reason; the decision to marry despite the creature's threat is nearly mad in its recklessness. In telling the story to Walton, he remarks

that the creature "as if possessed of magic powers... had blinded him [Victor] to his real intentions." By this point in the novel, the creature has taken on supernatural proportions: it is as though he were the unleashed wrath of hell itself. Thus the earthly weapons that Frankenstein carries to protect himself against the creature seem futile in the extreme.

Significantly, Frankenstein compares himself and Elizabeth to Adam and Eve. He says that his "paradisiacal dreams of love and joy" are dashed by the realization that "the apple was already eaten, and the angel's arm bared to drive [him] from all hope." This Biblical allusion has a number of ramifications. The apple of which Eve ate came from the Tree of Knowledge, which God had forbidden them to touch; it was for their curiosity that the first people were cast out of Paradise. Similarly, Frankenstein's misfortune befell him as a result of his overweening scientific curiosity and his desire to defy the work of God.

Frankenstein is aligned with both Adam and Eve, and, implicitly, with the creature himself: recall that the creature briefly compared himself to Adam during his reading of *Paradise Lost*. Strangely, this metaphor also serves to put the creature in the place of both God and the angel; he is thus positioned as the creator of Frankenstein himself. Their roles are now reversed.

Chapter 23:

Night has fallen by the time Victor and Elizabeth land on the shores of Como. The wind rises with sudden violence, and Frankenstein becomes increasingly anxious: he is certain that either he or his creature will die tonight. Elizabeth, seeing his agitation, implores him to tell her what it is he fears. Though he attempts to console her, he cannot bring himself to reply to her question; he says only that it is a dreadful night.

Hoping to spare Elizabeth from the sight of the monster, Victor asks her to retire to her bedchamber. She complies, and Victor stalks the corridors of their villa, searching for any trace of the monster. At length, he hears a dreadful scream; too late, Victor realizes the enormity of his mistake.

Upon entering the bedroom, he finds Elizabeth lying strangled upon the bed, her clothes and hair in a state of disarray; the print of the monster's fingers are still fresh upon her neck. Unable to tolerate the shock, he collapses.

When he revives, he finds himself surrounded by the people of the inn; he escapes from them to the room in which Elizabeth's corpse is lying. He falls upon her body and takes it in his arms. Wracked by indescribable grief, he looks up to see the monster grinning at him through the windowpane. Victor fires his pistol, but the creature eludes him.

Frankenstein alerts the other guests of the murderer's presence, and they try in vain to apprehend him. Though he longs to aid them in their search, he is feeble as a result of his shock and misery; he is carried, barely conscious, to his bed. Realizing that he does not know whether his father and brother are safe, Victor gathers all of his strength and travels to Geneva. On the journey, he reflects that he has lost all hope of future happiness; no being in all creation is so miserable as he.

Though both Alphonse and Ernest are safe when Victor arrives, the former soon perishes upon hearing of the death of Elizabeth. Victor has no memory of the time that immediately followed the death of his father; he later learned that he was kept in a miserable asylum, having been declared mad.

Upon his release, all Victor is obsessed by thoughts of taking revenge upon his creature. He visits a magistrate to ask for the help of the law in apprehending the

creature. Though the official listens attentively, it is clear that he only half-believes Frankenstein's wild tale. He tells Victor, quite reasonably, that it would be nearly impossible to pursue a superhuman being of the kind he has described. Frankenstein is enraged, and vows that he will devote himself to the creature's destruction. He recognizes his lust for vengeance as a vice but says that, in his current state of wretchedness, it is "the devouring and only passion of his soul."

Analysis:

Once again, the natural landscape foreshadows impending violence: upon the arrival of the Frankensteins, the wind at Como grows violent and a storm arises. Predictably, nature has lost its power to reassure; now, it reflects the chaos and darkness that Victor carries.

There is great irony in Victor's inability to recognize the monster's true intentions. The reader knows that it is Elizabeth, and not Frankenstein, who will bear the brunt of the monster's wrath; there is thus great pathos in Victor's horror at his mistake. The guilt he feels at Elizabeth's death is twofold: he both created her destroyer and left her completely unprotected at the moment of her death.

Victor is now indistinguishable from his creature: both are utterly bereft, loveless, and alone. Both are sustained only by their desire to revenge themselves upon the other. In their hatred for one another, they are more closely bound together than ever before.

Chapter 24:

Frankenstein has lost the capacity for voluntary thought; his entire consciousness is occupied by fantasies of revenge. He resolves to leave Geneva forever because the country has become hateful to him in the absence of his loved ones. Taking a sum of money and his mother's jewels, he goes off in search of the monster.

Before leaving Geneva, however, he visits the graves of his family. He kisses the earth and vows to avenge their deaths; he calls upon "the wandering ministers of vengeance" and upon the spirits of the dead to aid him in his quest. Suddenly, Victor hears a "fiendish laugh," as though hell itself were mocking him. From out of the darkness, the creature whispers that he is "satisfied" that Frankenstein has determined to live.

For months, he pursues the creature over the better part of the earth. At times, he is guided in his search by peasants who have been frightened by the hideous apparition; at others, the creature himself leaves Frankenstein some clue of his whereabouts, so that Victor will not despair and abandon his quest. Victor feels that some good spirit protects him throughout this journey; it alone saves him from death. He has grown to despise his life, and only finds refuge in sleep; in dreams he is once again among his beloved dead.

The creature cuts taunting messages into trees and stones, in order to remind his creator of the absolute power he has over him. He provides Frankenstein with food and advises him to prepare himself for the intolerable cold of the North: it is into these icy wastelands that the creature intends to lead him. Though Frankenstein knows that this final journey will mean certain death, he pursues the monster without hesitation.

Upon seeing the creature traversing the ice on a dogsled, Frankenstein weeps tears of hope and joy. When he has almost overtaken his enemy, however, he inexplicably loses all trace of him. Shortly thereafter, the ice breaks apart, and Victor is set adrift on a single jagged floe. He is on the brink of death when Walton's ship appears in the distance.

Though Victor looks forward to the peace that death will bring him, he despises the idea of dying with his task is unfulfilled. He begs Walton to kill the creature if he shows himself to him no matter how eloquent and persuasive he seems.

Analysis:

Strangely enough, this final chapter of Victor's narration, in which he is suffering a decline, finds him more dynamic than he has been since the days of his first experiment. Revenge invigorates him, intoxicates him: the joy he feels at seeing the creature's sledge marks the first time he has been happy in innumerable months.

Frankenstein liberates himself from his prison of guilt, opting instead for one of wrath. In a certain sense, the creature has finally succeeded in gaining the companionship he always desired. Frankenstein is doomed to share the creature's life, and to follow him wherever he may go: the two are as close as a parent and child, or a lover and his beloved. It no longer matters who occupies which position: each reciprocates the obsession of the other.

The chase appears almost childish: the creature taunts his creator, and Frankenstein pursues him with no regard for sense or reason. If nothing else, it presents Frankenstein with a challenge; it once again calls forth the lust for conquest that motivated his scientific endeavors. The creature is his master, his leader, and his animating force. Now it is the monster that brings his maker to life: without his desire for revenge, Frankenstein would surely have died long ago.

UNIT- 5

History of the Age of Transition and Romanticism

Romanticism continued to grow through poets like Gray, Collins, Blake and Burns, rejecting rigid Augustinian rules and valuing imagination. By 1800 with poets like Burns and Blake, Romanticism had clearly arrived and influenced poetry through styles like the lyric, ballad and narrative poem.

Romanticism (also known as the **Romantic movement** or **Romantic era**) was an artistic and intellectual movement that originated in Europe towards the end of the 18th century. The purpose of the movement was to advocate for the importance of subjectivity, imagination, and appreciation of nature in society and culture in response to the Age of Enlightenment and the Industrial Revolution.

Romanticists rejected the social conventions of the time in favor of a moral outlook known as individualism. They argued that passion and intuition were crucial to understanding the world, and that beauty is more than merely an affair of form, but rather something that evokes a strong emotional response. With this philosophical foundation, the Romanticists elevated a number of key themes to which they were deeply committed: a reverence for nature and the supernatural, an idealization of the past as a nobler era, a fascination with the exotic and the mysterious, and a celebration of the heroic and the sublime.

The Romanticist movement had a particular fondness for the Middle Ages, which to them represented an era of chivalry, heroism, and a more organic relationship between humans and their environment. This idealization contrasted sharply with the values of their contemporary industrial society, which they considered alienating for its economic materialism and environmental degradation. The movement's illustration of the Middle Ages was a key theme in debates, with

allegations that Romanticist portrayals often overlooked the downsides of medieval life.

The consensus is that Romanticism peaked from 1800 until 1850. However, a "Late Romantic" period and "Neoromantic" revivals are also discussed. These extensions of the movement are characterized by a resistance to the increasingly experimental and abstract forms that culminated in modern art, and the deconstruction of traditional tonal harmony in music. They continued the Romantic ideal, stressing depth of emotion in art and music while showcasing technical mastery in a mature Romantic style. By the time of World War I though, the cultural and artistic climate had changed to such a degree that Romanticism essentially dispersed into subsequent movements. The final Late Romanticist figures to maintain the Romantic ideals died in the 1940s. Though they were still widely respected, they were seen as anachronisms at that point.

Romanticism was a complex movement, with a variety of viewpoints that permeated Western civilization across the globe. The movement and its opposing ideologies mutually shaped each other as time went on. After its end, Romantic thought and art exerted a sweeping influence on art and music, speculative fiction, philosophy, politics, and environmentalism that has endured into the present day.

The movement is the reference for the modern notion of "romanticization" and the act of "romanticizing" something.

For most of the Western world, Romanticism was at its peak from approximately 1800 to 1850. The first Romantic ideas arose from an earlier German Counter-Enlightenment movement called *Sturm und Drang* (German: "Storm and Stress"). This movement directly criticized the Enlightenment's position that humans can fully comprehend the world through rationality alone, suggesting

that intuition and emotion are key components of insight and understanding.^[1] Published in 1774, "The Sorrows of Young Werther" by Johann Wolfgang von Goethe began to shape the Romanticist movement and its ideals. The events and ideologies of the French Revolution were also direct influences on the movement; many early Romantics throughout Europe sympathized with the ideals and achievements of French revolutionaries.^[2]

A confluence of circumstances led to Romanticism's decline in the mid-19th century, including (but not limited to) the rise of Realism and Naturalism, Charles Darwin's publishing of the *Origin of Species*, the transition from widespread revolution in Europe to a more conservative climate, and a shift in public consciousness to the immediate impact of technology and urbanization on the working class. By World War I, Romanticism was overshadowed by new cultural, social, and political movements, many of them hostile to the perceived illusions and preoccupations of the Romantics.

However, Romanticism has had a lasting impact on Western civilization, and many works of art, music, and literature that embody the Romantic ideals have been made after the end of the Romantic Era. The movement's advocacy for nature appreciation is cited as an influence for current nature conservation efforts. The majority of film scores from the Golden Age of Hollywood were written in the lush orchestral Romantic style, and this genre of orchestral cinematic music is still often seen in films of the 21st century. The philosophical underpinnings of the movement have influenced modern political theory, both among liberals and conservatives.

The nature of Romanticism

As a term to cover the most distinctive writers who flourished in the last years of the 18th century and the first decades of the 19th, "Romantic" is indispensable but

also a little misleading: there was no self-styled “Romantic movement” at the time, and the great writers of the period did not call themselves Romantics. Not until August Wilhelm von Schlegel’s Vienna lectures of 1808–09 was a clear distinction established between the “organic,” “plastic” qualities of Romantic art and the “mechanical” character of Classicism.

Many of the age’s foremost writers thought that something new was happening in the world’s affairs, nevertheless. William Blake’s affirmation in 1793 that “a new heaven is begun” was matched a generation later by Percy Bysshe Shelley’s “The world’s great age begins anew.” “These, these will give the world another heart, / And other pulses,” wrote John Keats, referring to Leigh Hunt and William Wordsworth. Fresh ideals came to the fore; in particular, the ideal of freedom, long cherished in England, was being extended to every range of human endeavor. As that ideal swept through Europe, it became natural to believe that the age of tyrants might soon end.

The most notable feature of the poetry of the time is the new role of individual thought and personal feeling. Where the main trend of 18th-century poetics had been to praise the general, to see the poet as a spokesman of society addressing a cultivated and homogeneous audience and having as his end the conveyance of “truth,” the Romantics found the source of poetry in the particular, unique experience. Blake’s marginal comment on Sir Joshua Reynolds’s *Discourses* expresses the position with characteristic vehemence: “To Generalize is to be an Idiot. To Particularize is the alone Distinction of Merit.” The poet was seen as an individual distinguished from his fellows by the intensity of his perceptions, taking as his basic subject matter the workings of his own mind. Poetry was regarded as conveying its own truth; sincerity was the criterion by which it was to be judged.

The emphasis on feeling—seen perhaps at its finest in the poems of Robert Burns—was in some ways a continuation of the earlier “cult of sensibility”; and it is worth remembering that Alexander Pope praised his father as having known no language but the language of the heart. But feeling had begun to receive particular emphasis and is found in most of the Romantic definitions of poetry. Wordsworth called poetry “the spontaneous overflow of powerful feeling,” and in 1833 John Stuart Mill defined poetry as “feeling itself, employing thought only as the medium of its utterance.” It followed that the best poetry was that in which the greatest intensity of feeling was expressed, and hence a new importance was attached to the lyric. Another key quality of Romantic writing was its shift from the mimetic, or imitative, assumptions of the Neoclassical era to a new stress on imagination. Samuel Taylor Coleridge saw the imagination as the supreme poetic quality, a quasi-divine creative force that made the poet a godlike being. Samuel Johnson had seen the components of poetry as “invention, imagination and judgement,” but Blake wrote: “One Power alone makes a Poet: Imagination, the Divine Vision.” The poets of this period accordingly placed great emphasis on the workings of the unconscious mind, on dreams and reveries, on the supernatural, and on the childlike or primitive view of the world, this last being regarded as valuable because its clarity and intensity had not been overlaid by the restrictions of civilized “reason.” Rousseau’s sentimental conception of the “noble savage” was often invoked, and often by those who were ignorant that the phrase is Dryden’s or that the type was adumbrated in the “poor Indian” of Pope’s *An Essay on Man*. A further sign of the diminished stress placed on judgment is the Romantic attitude to form: if poetry must be spontaneous, sincere, intense, it should be fashioned primarily according to the dictates of the creative imagination. Wordsworth advised a young poet, “You feel strongly; trust to those feelings, and your poem will take its shape and proportions as a tree does from the vital principle

that actuates it.” This organic view of poetry is opposed to the classical theory of “genres,” each with its own linguistic decorum; and it led to the feeling that poetic sublimity was unattainable except in short passages.

Hand in hand with the new conception of poetry and the insistence on a new subject matter went a demand for new ways of writing. Wordsworth and his followers, particularly Keats, found the prevailing poetic diction of the late 18th century stale and stilted, or “gaudy and inane,” and totally unsuited to the expression of their perceptions. It could not be, for them, the language of feeling, and Wordsworth accordingly sought to bring the language of poetry back to that of common speech. Wordsworth’s own diction, however, often differs from his theory. Nevertheless, when he published his preface to *Lyrical Ballads* in 1800, the time was ripe for a change: the flexible diction of earlier 18th-century poetry had hardened into a merely conventional language.

Poetry

Blake, Wordsworth, and Coleridge

William Blake: *Pity*

Pity, color print finished in pen and watercolor by William Blake, 1795; in the Tate Gallery, London.(more)

Useful as it is to trace the common elements in Romantic poetry, there was little conformity among the poets themselves. It is misleading to read the poetry of the first Romantics as if it had been written primarily to express their feelings. Their concern was rather to change the intellectual climate of the age. William Blake had been dissatisfied since boyhood with the current state of poetry and what he considered the irreligious drabness of contemporary thought. His early

development of a protective shield of mocking humor with which to face a world in which science had become trifling and art inconsequential is visible in the satirical *An Island in the Moon* (written c. 1784–85); he then took the bolder step of setting aside sophistication in the visionary *Songs of Innocence* (1789). His desire for renewal encouraged him to view the outbreak of the French Revolution as a momentous event. In works such as *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (1790–93) and *Songs of Experience* (1794), he attacked the hypocrisies of the age and the impersonal cruelties resulting from the dominance of analytic reason in contemporary thought. As it became clear that the ideals of the Revolution were not likely to be realized in his time, he renewed his efforts to revise his contemporaries' view of the universe and to construct a new mythology centered not in the God of the Bible but in Urizen, a repressive figure of reason and law whom he believed to be the deity actually worshipped by his contemporaries. The story of Urizen's rise was set out in *The First Book of Urizen* (1794) and then, more ambitiously, in the unfinished manuscript *Vala* (later redrafted as *The Four Zoas*), written from about 1796 to about 1807.

Blake developed these ideas in the visionary narratives of *Milton* (1804–08) and *Jerusalem* (1804–20). Here, still using his own mythological characters, he portrayed the imaginative artist as the hero of society and suggested the possibility of redemption from the fallen (or Urizenic) condition.

William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge, meanwhile, were also exploring the implications of the French Revolution. Wordsworth, who lived in France in 1791–92 and fathered an illegitimate child there, was distressed when, soon after his return, Britain declared war on the republic, dividing his allegiance. For the rest of his career, he was to brood on those events, trying to develop a view of humanity that would be faithful to his twin sense of the pathos of individual

human fates and the unrealized potentialities in humanity as a whole. The first factor emerges in his early manuscript poems “The Ruined Cottage” and “The Pedlar” (both to form part of the later *Excursion*); the second was developed from 1797, when he and his sister, Dorothy, with whom he was living in the west of England, were in close contact with Coleridge. Stirred simultaneously by Dorothy’s immediacy of feeling, manifested everywhere in her *Journals* (written 1798–1803, published 1897), and by Coleridge’s imaginative and speculative genius, he produced the poems collected in *Lyrical Ballads* (1798). The volume began with Coleridge’s “The Rime of the Ancient Mariner,” continued with poems displaying delight in the powers of nature and the humane instincts of ordinary people, and concluded with the meditative “Lines Written a Few Miles Above Tintern Abbey,” Wordsworth’s attempt to set out his mature faith in nature and humanity.

His investigation of the relationship between nature and the human mind continued in the long autobiographical poem addressed to Coleridge and later titled *The Prelude* (1798–99 in two books; 1804 in five books; 1805 in 13 books; revised continuously and published posthumously, 1850). Here he traced the value for a poet of having been a child “fostered alike by beauty and by fear” by an upbringing in sublime surroundings. *The Prelude* constitutes the most significant English expression of the Romantic discovery of the self as a topic for art and literature. The poem also makes much of the work of memory, a theme explored as well in the “Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood.” In poems such as “Michael” and “The Brothers,” by contrast, written for the second volume of *Lyrical Ballads* (1800), Wordsworth dwelt on the pathos and potentialities of ordinary lives.

Coleridge's poetic development during these years paralleled Wordsworth's. Having briefly brought together images of nature and the mind in "The Eolian Harp" (1796), he devoted himself to more-public concerns in poems of political and social prophecy, such as "Religious Musings" and "The Destiny of Nations." Becoming disillusioned in 1798 with his earlier politics, however, and encouraged by Wordsworth, he turned back to the relationship between nature and the human mind. Poems such as "This Lime-Tree Bower My Prison," "The Nightingale," and "Frost at Midnight" (now sometimes called the "conversation poems" but collected by Coleridge himself as "Meditative Poems in Blank Verse") combine sensitive descriptions of nature with subtlety of psychological comment. "Kubla Khan" (1797 or 1798, published 1816), a poem that Coleridge said came to him in "a kind of Reverie," represented a new kind of exotic writing, which he also exploited in the supernaturalism of "The Ancient Mariner" and the unfinished "Christabel." After his visit to Germany in 1798–99, he renewed attention to the links between the subtler forces in nature and the human psyche; this attention bore fruit in letters, notebooks, literary criticism, theology, and philosophy. Simultaneously, his poetic output became sporadic. "Dejection: An Ode" (1802), another meditative poem, which first took shape as a verse letter to Sara Hutchinson, Wordsworth's sister-in-law, memorably describes the suspension of his "shaping spirit of Imagination."

The work of both poets was directed back to national affairs during these years by the rise of Napoleon. In 1802 Wordsworth dedicated a number of sonnets to the patriotic cause. The death in 1805 of his brother John, who was a captain in the merchant navy, was a grim reminder that, while he had been living in retirement as a poet, others had been willing to sacrifice themselves. From this time the theme of duty was to be prominent in his poetry. His

political essay *Concerning the Relations of Great Britain, Spain and Portugal...as Affected by the Convention of Cintra* (1809) agreed with Coleridge's periodical *The Friend* (1809–10) in deploring the decline of principle among statesmen. When *The Excursion* appeared in 1814 (the time of Napoleon's first exile), Wordsworth announced the poem as the central section of a longer projected work, *The Recluse*, "a philosophical Poem, containing views of Man, Nature, and Society." The plan was not fulfilled, however, and *The Excursion* was left to stand in its own right as a poem of moral and religious consolation for those who had been disappointed by the failure of French revolutionary ideals.

Portrait of poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge

Samuel Taylor Coleridge, detail of an oil painting by Washington Allston, 1814; in the National Portrait Gallery, London.(more)

Both Wordsworth and Coleridge benefited from the advent in 1811 of the Regency, which brought a renewed interest in the arts. Coleridge's lectures on Shakespeare became fashionable, his play *Remorse* was briefly produced, and his volume of poems *Christabel; Kubla Khan: A Vision; The Pains of Sleep* was published in 1816. *Biographia Literaria* (1817), an account of his own development, combined philosophy and literary criticism in a new way and made an enduring and important contribution to literary theory. Coleridge settled at Highgate in 1816, and he was sought there as "the most impressive talker of his age" (in the words of the essayist William Hazlitt). His later religious writings made a considerable impact on Victorian readers.

Other poets of the early Romantic period

In his own lifetime, Blake's poetry was scarcely known. Sir Walter Scott, by contrast, was thought of as a major poet for his vigorous and evocative verse

narratives *The Lay of the Last Minstrel* (1805) and *Marmion* (1808). Other verse writers were also highly esteemed. The *Elegiac Sonnets* (1784) of Charlotte Smith and the *Fourteen Sonnets* (1789) of William Lisle Bowles were received with enthusiasm by Coleridge. Thomas Campbell is now chiefly remembered for his patriotic lyrics such as “Ye Mariners of England” and “The Battle of Hohenlinden” (1807) and for the critical preface to his *Specimens of the British Poets* (1819); Samuel Rogers was known for his brilliant table talk (published 1856, after his death, as *Recollections of the Table-Talk of Samuel Rogers*), as well as for his exquisite but exiguous poetry. Another admired poet of the day was Thomas Moore, whose *Irish Melodies* began to appear in 1808. His highly colored narrative *Lalla Rookh: An Oriental Romance* (1817) and his satirical poetry were also immensely popular. Charlotte Smith was not the only significant woman poet in this period. Helen Maria Williams’s *Poems* (1786), Ann Batten Cristall’s *Poetical Sketches* (1795), Mary Robinson’s *Sappho and Phaon* (1796), and Mary Tighe’s *Psyche* (1805) all contain notable work.

Robert Southey was closely associated with Wordsworth and Coleridge and was looked upon as a prominent member, with them, of the “Lake school” of poetry. His originality is best seen in his ballads and his nine “English Eclogues,” three of which were first published in the 1799 volume of his *Poems* with a prologue explaining that these verse sketches of contemporary life bore “no resemblance to any poems in our language.” His “Oriental” narrative poems *Thalaba the Destroyer* (1801) and *The Curse of Kehama* (1810) were successful in their own time, but his fame is based on his prose work—the *Life of Nelson* (1813), the *History of the Peninsular War* (1823–32), and his classic formulation of the children’s tale “The Three Bears.”

George Crabbe wrote poetry of another kind: his sensibility, his values, much of his diction, and his heroic couplet verse form belong to the 18th century. He differs from the earlier Augustans, however, in his subject matter, concentrating on realistic, unsentimental accounts of the life of the poor and the middle classes. He shows considerable narrative gifts in his collections of verse tales (in which he anticipates many short-story techniques) and great powers of description. His antipastoral *The Village* appeared in 1783. After a long silence, he returned to poetry with *The Parish Register* (1807), *The Borough* (1810), *Tales in Verse* (1812), and *Tales of the Hall* (1819), which gained him great popularity in the early 19th century.

The later Romantics: Shelley, Keats, and Byron

The poets of the next generation shared their predecessors' passion for liberty (now set in a new perspective by the Napoleonic Wars) and were in a position to learn from their experiments. Percy Bysshe Shelley in particular was deeply interested in politics, coming early under the spell of the anarchist views of William Godwin, whose *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice* had appeared in 1793. Shelley's revolutionary ardor caused him to claim in his critical essay "A Defence of Poetry" (1821, published 1840) that "the most unfailing herald, companion, and follower of the awakening of a great people to work a beneficial change in opinion or institution, is poetry," and that poets are "the unacknowledged legislators of the world." This fervor burns throughout the early *Queen Mab* (1813), the long *Laon and Cythna* (retitled *The Revolt of Islam*, 1818), and the lyrical drama *Prometheus Unbound* (1820). Shelley saw himself at once as poet and prophet, as the fine "Ode to the West Wind" (1819) makes clear. Despite his grasp of practical politics, however, it is a mistake to look for concreteness in his poetry, where his concern is with subtleties of perception and with the underlying forces of nature: his most characteristic images are of sky and weather, of lights and fires. His poetic stance

invites the reader to respond with similar outgoing aspiration. It adheres to the Rousseauistic belief in an underlying spirit in individuals, one truer to human nature itself than the behavior evinced and approved by society. In that sense his material is transcendental and cosmic and his expression thoroughly appropriate. Possessed of great technical brilliance, he is, at his best, a poet of excitement and power.

Portrait of poet John Keats

John Keats, detail of an oil painting by Joseph Severn, 1821; in the National Portrait Gallery, London.(more)

John Keats, by contrast, was a poet so sensuous and physically specific that his early work, such as *Endymion* (1818), could produce an over-luxuriant, cloying effect. As the program set out in his early poem “Sleep and Poetry” shows, however, Keats was determined to discipline himself: even before February 1820, when he first began to cough blood, he may have known that he had not long to live, and he devoted himself to the expression of his vision with feverish intensity. He experimented with many kinds of poems: “Isabella” (published 1820), an adaptation of a tale by Giovanni Boccaccio, is a tour de force of craftsmanship in its attempt to reproduce a medieval atmosphere and at the same time a poem involved in contemporary politics.

His epic fragment *Hyperion* (begun in 1818 and abandoned, published 1820; later begun again and published posthumously as *The Fall of Hyperion* in 1856) has a new spareness of imagery, but Keats soon found the style too Miltonic and decided to give himself up to what he called “other sensations.” Some of these “other sensations” are found in the poems of 1819, Keats’s *annus mirabilis*: “The Eve of St. Agnes” and the great odes “To a Nightingale,” “On a Grecian Urn,” and “To

Autumn.” These, with the *Hyperion* poems, represent the summit of Keats’s achievement, showing what has been called “the disciplining of sensation into symbolic meaning,” the complex themes being handled with a concrete richness of detail. His superb letters show the full range of the intelligence at work in his poetry.

George Gordon, Lord Byron, who differed from Shelley and Keats in themes and manner, was at one with them in reflecting their shift toward “Mediterranean” topics. Having thrown down the gauntlet in his early poem *English Bards and Scotch Reviewers* (1809), in which he directed particular scorn at poets of sensibility and declared his own allegiance to Milton, Dryden, and Pope, he developed a poetry of dash and flair, in many cases with a striking hero. His two longest poems, *Childe Harold’s Pilgrimage* (1812–18) and *Don Juan* (1819–24), his masterpiece, provided alternative personae for himself, the one a bitter and melancholy exile among the historic sites of Europe, the other a picaresque adventurer enjoying a series of amorous adventures. The gloomy and misanthropic vein was further mined in dramatic poems such as *Manfred* (1817) and *Cain* (1821), which helped to secure his reputation in Europe, but he is now remembered best for witty, ironic, and less portentous writings, such as *Beppo* (1818), in which he first used the ottava rima form. The easy, nonchalant, biting style developed there became a formidable device in *Don Juan* and in his satire on Southey, *The Vision of Judgment* (1822).

Other poets of the later period

John Clare, a Northamptonshire man of humble background, achieved early success with *Poems Descriptive of Rural Life and Scenery* (1820), *The Village Minstrel* (1821), and *The Shepherd’s Calendar* (1827). Both his reputation and his mental health collapsed in the late 1830s. He spent the later years of his life in

an asylum in Northampton; the poetry he wrote there was rediscovered in the 20th century. His natural simplicity and lucidity of diction, his intent observation, his almost Classical poise, and the unassuming dignity of his attitude to life make him one of the most quietly moving of English poets. Thomas Lovell Beddoes, whose violent imagery and obsession with death and the macabre recall the Jacobean dramatists, represents an imagination at the opposite pole; metrical virtuosity is displayed in the songs and lyrical passages from his over-sensational tragedy *Death's Jest-Book* (begun 1825; published posthumously, 1850). Another minor writer who found inspiration in the 17th century was George Darley, some of whose songs from *Nepenthe* (1835) keep their place in anthologies. The comic writer Thomas Hood also wrote poems of social protest, such as "The Song of the Shirt" (1843) and "The Bridge of Sighs," as well as the graceful *Plea of the Midsummer Fairies* (1827). Felicia Hemans's best-remembered poem, "Casabianca," appeared in her volume *The Forest Sanctuary* (1825). This was followed in 1828 by the more substantial *Records of Woman*.

The novel: from the Gothic novel to Austen and Scott

Flourishing as a form of entertainment during the Romantic period, the novel underwent several important developments in this period. One was the invention of the Gothic novel. Another was the appearance of a politically engaged fiction in the years immediately before the French Revolution. A third was the rise of women writers to prominence in prose fiction.

The sentimental tradition of Richardson and Sterne persisted until the 1790s with Henry Brooke's *The Fool of Quality* (1765–70), Henry Mackenzie's *The Man of Feeling* (1771), and Charles Lamb's *A Tale of Rosamund Gray and Old Blind*

Margaret (1798). Novels of this kind were, however, increasingly mocked by critics in the later years of the 18th century.

The comic realism of Fielding and Smollett continued in a more sporadic way. John Moore gave a cosmopolitan flavor to the worldly wisdom of his predecessors in *Zeluco* (1786) and *Mordaunt* (1800). Frances Burney carried the comic realist manner into the field of female experience with the novels *Evelina* (1778), *Cecilia* (1782), and *Camilla* (1796). Her discovery of the comic and didactic potential of a plot charting a woman's progress from the nursery to the altar would be important for several generations of female novelists.

More striking than these continuations of previous modes, however, was Horace Walpole's invention, in *The Castle of Otranto* (1764), of what became known as the Gothic novel. Walpole's intention was to "blend" the fantastic plot of "ancient romance" with the realistic characterization of "modern" (or novel) romance. Characters would respond with terror to extraordinary events, and readers would vicariously participate. Walpole's innovation was not significantly imitated until the 1790s, when—perhaps because the violence of the French Revolution created a taste for a correspondingly extreme mode of fiction—a torrent of such works appeared.